



ACQLERATE

MODULE 13

# Veteran Transition: From Uniform to Acquisition

*A practical guide for service members and veterans moving into defense acquisition on either side: translating military experience, the government civilian path and its hiring authorities, the contractor path and billability, keeping and valuing your clearance, the post-government employment rules, starting a veteran-owned business, and the first ninety days and five-year map.*

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7 Lessons · ~152 Minutes · Lesson Book Edition

## Course Lessons

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| 01 | You Already Did This: Translating Military Experience Into Acquisition Language                             | 20 min |
| 02 | The Government Civilian Path: USAJOBS, Series, Preferences, and the Acquisition Workforce                   | 24 min |
| 03 | The Contractor Path: Roles, Billability, and What a Defense Contractor Is Actually Buying When It Hires You | 22 min |
| 04 | Your Clearance Is an Asset: Keeping It, Transferring It, and Knowing What It Is Worth                       | 18 min |
| 05 | Post-Government Employment Rules: The Revolving Door, Explained Without a Law Degree                        | 24 min |
| 06 | Starting a Veteran-Owned Business: SDVOSB, VOSB, and the First Contract                                     | 22 min |
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## VETERAN TRANSITION: FROM UNIFORM TO ACQUISITION · LESSON 1

# You Already Did This: Translating Military Experience Into Acquisition Language

20 min

*Why acquisition is closer to what you did in uniform than it looks, the vocabulary crosswalk from military planning, logistics, and leadership to program management and contracting terms, what parts of your record acquisition employers actually value, how to rewrite a military resume so a civilian hiring manager or a contractor recruiter can read it, and the habits from service that help and the ones that get in the way.*

## The Reassurance, and Why It Is True

Defense acquisition is the process by which the Department turns money into capability: figuring out what the force needs, getting the money, choosing how to buy it, managing the contractor who builds it, testing it, fielding it, and keeping it running. If you served, you were on the receiving end of every step of that process. You wrote or lived requirements. You managed property and budgets. You planned operations with uncertain information and incomplete resources. You led people you did not choose toward outcomes you did not set. You operated inside regulations and reporting systems. Acquisition uses different words for all of it, and the pace, the authorities, and the culture differ in ways the rest of this module covers. But the underlying work is one you have done. The hard part of the transition is translation, not learning.

### IN PLAIN TERMS

Think of moving abroad with a valid driver's license. You already know how to drive. What you need is the local license: the same skill, written in the local system's terms, plus a few new road signs to learn. Nobody makes you relearn steering. Your military record works the same way. The planning, resourcing, and leading are already there, and the job is converting them into acquisition vocabulary that a civilian hiring manager can read.

## The Vocabulary Crosswalk

| YOU CALLED IT                         | ACQUISITION CALLS IT                                                 | WHAT IS THE SAME                                                                   |
|---------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Mission statement, commander's intent | Requirement, capability need                                         | A validated statement of what must be achieved, approved by someone with authority |
| Operations order, plan                | Acquisition strategy, program plan, integrated master plan           | A written plan with phases, tasks, responsibilities, and decision points           |
| Troops to task, resourcing            | Cost estimate, budget, staffing plan                                 | Matching people, money, and time to the work                                       |
| Timeline, synch matrix                | Integrated master schedule, milestones                               | Sequenced tasks with dependencies and dates                                        |
| Risk assessment                       | Risk register, risk management plan                                  | Identifying what could go wrong, how likely, how bad, and what to do about it      |
| Higher headquarters, adjacent units   | Stakeholders, milestone decision authority, program executive office | The people whose decisions and support you need and do not control                 |
| After-action review, lessons learned  | Program review, post-award debrief, CPARS                            | Structured evaluation of performance against the plan                              |
| Property book, hand receipt           | Government-furnished property, inventory, contract deliverables      | Accountability for things the government owns                                      |
| Task, condition, standard             | Performance work statement, acceptable quality level                 | What must be done, under what conditions, to what measurable standard              |
| Fitness report, evaluation            | CPARS, award fee determination                                       | Formal, consequential performance assessment                                       |

## What Acquisition Employers Actually Value From Your Record

Government hiring managers and contractor recruiters look at a veteran's record for a specific set of things, and it is worth knowing which. They value operational credibility: you know what the equipment is for and what happens when it fails, which no amount of civilian experience provides. They value an active security clearance, which the clearance lesson covers. They value experience with government systems, budgets, and property, even at small scale. They value leadership of people and planning under pressure. They value familiarity with the customer culture: you can walk into a program office or a unit and speak the language. They do not, in general, value rank for its own sake, unit prestige, or awards, and they are often unable to read any of those anyway. Translate what you did into scope (how much money, how many people, how big an operation), outcomes (what changed because of your work), and skills (what you can do again in the new job).

## Rewriting the Military Resume

- **Remove the acronyms** Every one. If a term cannot be replaced with plain English, explain it in a few words the first time.
- **State scope in civilian units** "Managed a \$4.2M annual operating budget and 140 personnel across three sites," not "S4 for a BN."
- **Lead with outcomes** What improved, what was delivered, what was fixed, in numbers where possible. Duties are less interesting than results.
- **Translate the role** Operations officer becomes "led planning and execution for a 600-person organization"; supply sergeant becomes "managed inventory, procurement requests, and accountability for \$18M in equipment."
- **Name the transferable skills explicitly** Program management, budgeting, logistics, risk management, stakeholder coordination, regulatory compliance. Use the job posting's words.
- **Keep it to two pages** Civilian readers stop. Cut the awards list to the ones that mean something outside the service, if any.
- **Have a civilian read it** Someone with no military background. If they cannot explain what you did, rewrite it.

### REAL TALK

Nobody in a program office cares that you were a company commander. They care that you ran a 130-person organization with a budget and a mission, made decisions on bad information, and delivered anyway. Those are the same fact. Only one of them is written in a language the hiring manager can read. Most veterans who struggle here are not underqualified, they are untranslated, and the maddening part is watching civilians fail to see something that is completely obvious to you. Do the translation yourself, once, properly, and stop waiting for anyone else to do it.

## Habits That Help, and Habits That Get in the Way

Service habits that serve you well in acquisition: showing up prepared, writing clearly and briefly, respecting timelines, owning outcomes, taking care of the people who work for you, and treating regulations as things to be understood rather than argued with. Habits that get in the way: expecting decisions to be made and obeyed (acquisition decisions are negotiated among people who do not report to each other), expecting speed (a program measures time in years), treating the contracting officer as a staff officer who works for you (the CO has authority you do not), briefing when you should write, and reading civilian informality as a lack of seriousness. The first-ninety-days lesson goes deeper on the culture; the point here is that you will need to consciously turn some things off, and that is normal.

One sentence to teach your team: **acquisition is the work you already did, planning, resourcing, leading, and delivering under regulation, described in a different vocabulary, and the transition is mostly translating your record into scope, outcomes, and skills that a civilian reader can see.**

## INTERMEDIATE

### Mapping Specialties to Acquisition Roles

Different military specialties map naturally to different acquisition roles, and knowing your nearest match focuses the search. Logistics and supply specialties map to life cycle logistics, sustainment program management, and property administration. Operations and planning roles map to program management, integrated master schedule ownership, and requirements. Finance, comptroller, and resource management roles map to business financial management, cost estimating, and budget analysis. Maintenance and technical specialties map to engineering and technical management, test and evaluation, and field service roles on the contractor side. Intelligence and communications specialties map to program offices in their domains and to security roles. Contracting specialists in uniform map directly to the 1102 series and to contractor contracts management. Recruiters and instructors map surprisingly well to business development and training roles. None of these is a rule, and people cross them constantly; they are the shortest paths.

### The Two Sides: Government and Contractor

The next two lessons cover each path in detail; here is the choice in one paragraph. The government civilian path offers stability, a pension that combines with military retirement under known rules, a mission continuity you will recognize, and a defined certification and grade ladder; it pays less at the top, hires slowly, and moves at the government's pace. The contractor path offers higher pay, faster hiring, more variety, and a direct connection between your work and the company's revenue; it carries billability pressure, contract-tied job security, and a customer who is not your employer. Many veterans do both over a career, and the crossing point is usually a clearance and a customer relationship. Decide based on what you want the next five years to feel like, not on which side sounds more familiar.

### Interviewing Without Rank

In uniform, your rank told people how to read you before you spoke. In a civilian interview, nothing does. Interviewers are asking three things: can you do the job, will you fit, and do you want it. Answer with specific stories in the STAR shape (situation, task, action, result) using translated language and civilian units. Avoid the passive voice of military writing ("the mission was accomplished"); say what you did. Do not lead with hardship or sacrifice; lead with what you delivered. Ask about the program, the customer, and the team, because those questions show you understand what the job is. And be ready for "why are you leaving the military," with an answer about what you are moving toward rather than what you are leaving.

## Using the Transition Programs

The services' transition assistance programs, the DoD SkillBridge program (which allows up to the last 180 days of service to be spent in an approved industry training or internship program while still on active duty, verify current rules), veteran employment programs run by nonprofits and large contractors, and the federal hiring preferences all exist for you. SkillBridge in particular is the best on-ramp available to the contractor side and increasingly to government offices: you work in the job before you leave service, the employer sees you perform, and the offer usually follows. Apply early, because the good SkillBridge positions fill months ahead. Treat every program as a door, not a guarantee; the work of translating and networking is still yours.

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**ADVANCED**

## What Senior Veterans Bring, and What They Have to Unlearn

Senior enlisted leaders and field-grade officers bring judgment, organizational skill, and a network that junior transitioners do not have, and acquisition organizations know it. They also have the most to unlearn. Acquisition rewards people who can build consensus among peers without authority, who can write a persuasive memorandum, who can wait a year for a decision without losing focus, and who can accept that the contracting officer, the tester, and the budget analyst each have a veto. A senior leader who tries to command a program office generates resistance without knowing why. The ones who thrive shift from directing to persuading in the first ninety days, ask more questions than they answer for six months, and use their judgment on what matters rather than on how things should be done.

## The Post-Government Employment Rules Start Now

If you are in an acquisition-related role in uniform (contracting, program management, source selection, contract oversight), the rules about seeking and accepting employment with contractors apply to you while you are still serving, and some restrictions follow you after you leave. The ethics lesson in this module covers them in detail. The point to take from this lesson is that the translation and networking you are about to do can create conflicts: talking to a contractor about a job while you are involved in a matter affecting that contractor is a problem, and the fix is disclosure and disqualification, done in writing, before the conversation. Talk to your ethics counselor before you start the job search, not after you get an offer.

## Three Translations, Worked

Military experience rewritten for a civilian acquisition reader.

**Battalion S4 (logistics officer)** LOGISTICS

Before: "S4, 2-XX IN BN; managed BN property book and supply ops." After: "Directed logistics, procurement requests, and property accountability for a 650-person organization with \$42M in equipment; reduced inventory discrepancies by 60 percent over 18 months."

Scope in dollars and people, an outcome in numbers, no acronyms.

**Platoon sergeant** LEADERSHIP

Before: "PSG, 3rd PLT." After: "Senior supervisor for a 40-person team; responsible for training, readiness, equipment worth \$6M, and performance evaluation; led the team through two deployments with full accountability of personnel and equipment."

Supervision, training, accountability, results.

**Contracting NCO** CONTRACTING

Before: "51C, awarded contracts IAW FAR/DFARS." After: "Contract specialist; awarded and administered \$28M in contracts for services, construction, and supplies under federal acquisition regulations; managed vendor performance and payment for 45 active awards."

This one translates almost directly; the numbers are what was missing.

**WHAT SENIOR PMS DO DIFFERENTLY**

Hiring managers who bring veterans into acquisition successfully read the record for scope, outcomes, and customer credibility, not rank, and pair the new hire with a mentor who explains the culture. Veterans who transition well translate their record once and thoroughly, pick the path by what they want the next five years to feel like, use SkillBridge and the preferences as doors, talk to ethics counsel before the search, and switch from directing to persuading before anyone has to tell them.

**BUILD ON THIS**

- **Roles & Career Paths** The acquisition roles you are mapping to
- **What Program Managers Actually Do** The job in practice
- **The First Ninety Days** The culture shift in detail

## Key Terms

### Crosswalk

A mapping from one vocabulary to another. Here, from the words the military uses for planning, resourcing, and execution to the words acquisition uses for the same things.

### Program Management

Leading a defined effort to deliver a capability on cost, schedule, and performance. In military terms, the operations officer's job applied to buying and building things.

### Requirement

A validated statement of what the user needs. The acquisition equivalent of a mission statement and commander's intent, written down and approved.

### Stakeholder

Anyone with a say or a stake in the outcome: the user, the funder, the contracting office, the tester, leadership. The acquisition version of adjacent units, higher headquarters, and supporting elements.

### Cost, Schedule, Performance

The three dimensions every program is measured on. The acquisition version of troops, time, and mission.

### Contracting Officer (CO)

The only person with authority to bind the government to a contract. Not in your chain of command; a peer with a warrant you do not have.

### Deliverable

A defined product, report, or result the contract requires. The acquisition version of a task with a standard and a due date.

### Resume Translation

Rewriting military roles, units, and achievements in terms a civilian reader understands: scope, budget, people, outcomes, without acronyms or assumed context.

### Billet

A position. Civilians say role, position, or job. Using billet in an interview marks you as untranslated.

### Transferable Skill

Something you did in uniform that has direct value in the new role, stated in the new role's terms: planning under uncertainty, resource management, leading through others, operating in a regulated environment.

## Knowledge Check

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What is the hard part of a veteran's transition into acquisition?

- A. Learning entirely new work
- ✓ B. Translation: describing work you already did in a vocabulary civilian readers understand
- C. Passing a test
- D. Getting a clearance

### WHY

Planning, resourcing, leading, and delivering under regulation are the same work with different words.

The acquisition equivalent of commander's intent is:

- A. The contract
- ✓ B. The requirement or capability need
- C. The budget
- D. The CPARS

### WHY

A validated statement of what must be achieved, approved by someone with authority.

What do acquisition employers value most from a veteran's record?

- A. Rank and awards
- ✓ B. Operational credibility, an active clearance, experience with government systems and budgets, leadership, and customer culture fluency
- C. Unit prestige
- D. Time in service

### WHY

Translate into scope, outcomes, and skills; rank and awards rarely read.

**How should scope appear on a translated resume?**

A. By unit designation

✓ **B. In civilian units: dollars managed, people led, sites, equipment value**

C. By billet title

D. By rank

**WHY**

"Managed a \$4.2M budget and 140 personnel" reads; "S4 for a BN" does not.

**Which service habit gets in the way in acquisition?**

A. Showing up prepared

✓ **B. Expecting decisions to be made and obeyed, when acquisition decisions are negotiated among people who do not report to each other**

C. Writing briefly

D. Respecting timelines

**WHY**

The CO, the tester, and the budget analyst each have a veto; persuasion replaces command.

**A finance or comptroller specialty maps most directly to:**

A. Test and evaluation

✓ **B. Business financial management, cost estimating, and budget analysis**

C. Security

D. Field service

**WHY**

Specialty-to-role maps are shortest paths, not rules.

**What does SkillBridge allow?**

A. Early retirement

✓ **B. Up to the last 180 days of service spent in an approved industry training or internship while still on active duty**

C. A guaranteed government job

D. A clearance upgrade

**WHY**

The best on-ramp to the contractor side; good positions fill months ahead. Verify current rules.

**In a civilian interview, how should you answer?**

A. With rank and unit history

✓ **B. With specific STAR stories in translated language and civilian units, leading with what you delivered**

C. With a list of awards

D. With hardship and sacrifice

**WHY**

Interviewers ask whether you can do the job, will fit, and want it.

**What must senior veterans most often unlearn?**

A. Writing skills

✓ **B. Directing instead of persuading; acquisition rewards consensus among peers without authority**

C. Attention to detail

D. Taking care of people

**WHY**

Shift from directing to persuading in the first ninety days; ask more than you answer for six months.

**Match the military term to its acquisition counterpart:****CORRECT MATCHES**

|                           |                                                         |
|---------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| Operations order          | Acquisition strategy and program plan                   |
| Troops to task            | Cost estimate and staffing plan                         |
| After-action review       | Program review and CPARS                                |
| Task, condition, standard | Performance work statement and acceptable quality level |

**WHY**

The crosswalk maps planning, resourcing, evaluation, and standards vocabulary.

**Order the steps to translate a military resume:****CORRECT ORDER**

1. Remove every acronym or explain it in plain English
2. Restate scope in dollars, people, and sites
3. Lead each role with outcomes in numbers
4. Name transferable skills using the job posting's words
5. Have a civilian with no military background read it

**WHY**

Strip acronyms, restate scope and outcomes, name the skills in the posting's words, then test it on a civilian reader.

**When should someone in an acquisition-related military role talk to an ethics counselor about a job search?**

A. After accepting an offer

**✓ B. Before starting the search, because seeking employment with a contractor while involved in a matter affecting it requires disclosure and disqualification**

C. Never; the rules apply only after separation

D. Only for O-7 and above

**WHY**

Some restrictions apply during service and some follow you after. Written disclosure first.

## VETERAN TRANSITION: FROM UNIFORM TO ACQUISITION · LESSON 2

# The Government Civilian Path: USAJOBS, Series, Preferences, and the Acquisition Workforce

24 min

*How federal acquisition hiring works for a veteran: the occupational series that make up the acquisition workforce (1102 contracting, 0343 and 0301 program management and analysis, 1101, 0501 and 0560 financial, 0346 logistics, 0801 and 0855 engineering), veterans' preference and the special appointing authorities, reading a USAJOBS announcement the way HR does, the DAWIA certification system, the intern and developmental programs, and how the GS grade ladder and military retirement combine.*

## The Acquisition Workforce Is Hiring, and It Is Hiring You

The DoD acquisition workforce is large, aging, and under a standing mandate to grow and renew. Contracting offices in particular have been short of qualified people for years. Veterans are the natural pipeline: the clearance, the customer knowledge, the preference in hiring, and the special authorities that let agencies bring you in without a full competition all point the same way. The obstacles are the ones every federal applicant faces (the announcement format, the HR screen, the slow timeline) plus the translation problem the previous lesson covered. This lesson is the mechanics: which jobs, which authorities, how the announcements work, and what the certification system will ask of you once you are in.

## The Acquisition Occupational Series

| SERIES                                                     | WHAT IT IS                                                                                   | TYPICAL ENTRY                                                                                               | MILITARY BACKGROUND THAT MAPS                                                   |
|------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1102 Contract Specialist / Contracting Officer             | Solicits, awards, and administers contracts; becomes a CO with a warrant                     | GS-7 to GS-9 intern, GS-11 to GS-12 experienced; bachelor's degree required (verify current education rule) | Contracting specialties directly; supply, finance, and operations with a degree |
| 0343 Management and Program Analyst                        | Program office analysis, planning, process, and reporting; a common program management entry | GS-9 to GS-12                                                                                               | Operations, planning, staff officers and NCOs                                   |
| 0301 Miscellaneous Administration and Program              | Program managers and generalist program office roles                                         | GS-11 to GS-13                                                                                              | Operations and leadership roles                                                 |
| 0346 Logistics Management Specialist                       | Life cycle logistics, sustainment, supportability                                            | GS-9 to GS-12                                                                                               | Logistics, supply, maintenance management                                       |
| 0501 / 0560 Financial Administration / Budget Analyst      | Business financial management, budget execution, PPBE support                                | GS-9 to GS-12                                                                                               | Finance, comptroller, resource management                                       |
| 0801 / 0855 / 0854 General, Electronics, Computer Engineer | Engineering and technical management, systems engineering                                    | GS-11 to GS-12 with a degree                                                                                | Technical specialties with an engineering degree                                |
| 1101 General Business and Industry                         | Business, industrial, and property administration roles                                      | GS-9 to GS-12                                                                                               | Broad; often a step into 1102                                                   |
| 1670 Equipment Specialist                                  | Technical support to programs on specific equipment                                          | GS-9 to GS-11                                                                                               | Maintenance and technical specialties without a degree                          |

## Veterans' Preference and the Special Authorities

In open-to-the-public hiring, eligible veterans receive preference: five points added to a passing score for most eligible veterans, ten points for veterans with a service-connected disability and certain others, and under category rating, preference eligibles are placed at the top of their quality category (with ten-point disabled veterans placed above everyone in most cases). That is the preference most people know. Less known and often more useful are the special appointing authorities. The Veterans Recruitment Appointment lets an agency hire an eligible veteran directly, without competition, into positions up to GS-11. The 30 percent or more disabled veteran authority lets an agency hire non-competitively at any grade. The Veterans Employment Opportunities Act lets you apply to merit promotion announcements otherwise closed to

outsiders. Each has its own eligibility rules (verify current); together they mean a hiring manager who wants you can usually find a way to bring you in without the full competitive process. The lesson is to make hiring managers want you, then remind them of the authorities.

## Reading a USAJOBS Announcement the Way HR Does

An announcement is not a job description; it is a screening instrument. HR specialists check your resume against the qualification standard for the series and grade (general experience, specialized experience, education), against the announcement's specialized experience statement (a paragraph of duties you must show you have done at the next lower grade for one year), and against the self-assessment questionnaire. A resume that does not use the announcement's words for the specialized experience is rated ineligible by a person who does not know what your military job involved. The federal resume is therefore long (three to five pages is normal), detailed, and mirrored to the announcement: each relevant experience block states the duties in the announcement's language, with hours per week, dates, supervisor, and grade equivalents. Answer the questionnaire at the highest honest level; understating it screens you out. Then attach every document the announcement asks for (DD-214, VA letter for ten-point preference, SF-15, transcripts), because a missing document is an automatic rejection.

### EXAMPLE (ILLUSTRATIVE)

A veteran who ran a battalion's training calendar applies to a GS-11 Management and Program Analyst (0343) announcement. The specialized experience statement asks for one year of "developing project schedules, tracking milestones, and reporting status to senior leaders." Her first resume says "ran the BN synch matrix," and HR rates her ineligible, because the screener cannot match those words to the statement. She rewrites the block in the announcement's own words: "Developed and maintained project schedules for 14 concurrent training events, tracked milestones weekly, and reported status to senior leaders," with hours per week, dates, and her supervisor. She attaches her DD-214. She has also met the hiring manager at a transition event, so she points out that the Veterans Recruitment Appointment (VRA) covers positions up to GS-11, which lets the office hire her directly.

## The Federal Application Checklist

- **Federal resume, not civilian resume** Three to five pages, mirrored to the announcement's specialized experience, with dates, hours, and supervisors. Keep a master version and tailor it per announcement.
- **DD-214 (member 4 or service 2 copy)** Required for preference; a statement of service if still serving with a separation date within the window.
- **SF-15 and VA letter** For ten-point preference; the letter must show the disability rating.
- **Transcripts** For any series with an education requirement (1102 especially) or for grade qualification by education.
- **Questionnaire answered honestly and fully** At the highest level you can support with the resume.

- **Announcement type** Open to the public (preference applies), merit promotion (use VEOA), or direct hire and special authority (contact the hiring office).
- **Timeline expectation** Weeks to months from close to offer, then security processing. Apply broadly and keep working the network.

#### REAL TALK

USAJOBS feels like it was designed to reject you, and in fairness, it sort of was. HR is screening hundreds of applications against a written standard, and anything ambiguous gets cut, because ambiguous is how you end up with a complaint. Veterans who get hired almost always did two things. They wrote the federal resume the way HR reads it, word for word against the announcement, which feels ridiculous and works anyway. And they found the hiring manager through the network, so a real person was watching for their name on the certificate. Neither one is cheating. Both are just how the machine actually runs.

One sentence to teach your team: **the federal acquisition workforce needs you and has authorities built to hire you, so write the federal resume in the announcement's words, attach every document, use the preference and the special authorities, and find the hiring manager who will be looking for your name.**

#### INTERMEDIATE

### DAWIA and What Certification Will Require

Once in an acquisition-coded position, you are in the acquisition workforce and subject to DAWIA certification. The system was restructured under the Back-to-Basics initiative into functional areas (contracting, program management, engineering and technical management, life cycle logistics, test and evaluation, business financial management and cost estimating, and others) with a foundational tier for most and practitioner and advanced tiers for the areas that have them. Certification requires specified training from the Defense Acquisition University (mostly online, some resident), experience in the field, and in some areas a credential or education requirement; contracting requires a bachelor's degree (verify the current education rule, which has changed). You will have a set period after entering the position to become certified, and the training is on government time and government money. Continuous learning points are required to stay current. For a veteran, DAWIA is good news: it is a defined ladder, it is paid for, and it produces a portable credential that contractors also recognize.

## Grades, Pay, and Where Veterans Enter

| GRADE            | TYPICAL ROLE                                        | COMMON ENTRY FOR                                              | NOTE                                                                  |
|------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| GS-7 /<br>GS-9   | Intern, trainee, junior specialist                  | Junior enlisted with a degree; developmental program entrants | Programs promote to GS-11 or 12 automatically on schedule             |
| GS-11            | Specialist, analyst                                 | Mid-grade NCOs and junior officers                            | VRA ceiling; a common first federal grade                             |
| GS-12            | Journeyman specialist, contract specialist, analyst | Senior NCOs, company-grade officers                           | The most common experienced entry grade                               |
| GS-13            | Senior specialist, CO, deputy PM, team lead         | Senior NCOs with acquisition experience, field-grade officers | Usually requires prior acquisition experience or a strong translation |
| GS-14 /<br>GS-15 | Division chief, PM, senior CO, branch head          | Field-grade and senior officers with acquisition backgrounds  | Competitive; often reached from within                                |

## The Developmental and Intern Programs

Each service and several agencies run structured entry programs for the acquisition workforce: contracting intern programs, service-level acquisition development programs, and DoD-wide pathways. They hire at GS-7 or GS-9 with a defined promotion schedule to GS-11 or GS-12, pay for the DAWIA training, rotate the intern through assignments, and often include a mobility agreement. For a veteran with a degree and no direct acquisition experience, these programs are the cleanest entry: the grade is lower than you might get elsewhere, but the ladder is automatic and the training is complete. Announcements appear on USAJOBS and on the services' civilian career sites, often in cycles; some are direct-hire. Apply to several; the programs are competitive but veterans do well in them.

## Military Retirement, Federal Retirement, and Buying Back Time

If you retired from the military, your retired pay continues while you work as a federal civilian, and you earn a separate federal pension under FERS. You may also deposit for your military service to have it count toward FERS (a military service credit deposit), but for retirees this generally requires waiving military retired pay, which is rarely worth it; for non-retiree veterans, the deposit is usually worth making because it adds years to the federal pension at low cost. The rules are detailed and consequential (verify with the agency's benefits office and a financial advisor); the point for planning is that the two systems combine in known ways, and a veteran entering federal service in their forties can build a meaningful second pension over a fifteen-year civilian career.

## ADVANCED

## Working the System From the Inside: How Hiring Managers Actually Hire

A hiring manager with a vacancy writes a position description, asks HR for a recruitment, chooses the announcement type, and waits weeks for a certificate of eligible candidates. They can influence who is on it by choosing the announcement type and, for veterans, by using a special authority to hire someone they have already identified. This is why the network matters: a manager who has met you at an industry event, a transition program, or through a mutual contact, and who wants you, can ask HR for a VRA or a 30 percent disabled veteran appointment and skip the certificate, or can watch for your name when the certificate arrives. Approach this as you would any professional relationship: learn what the office does, be useful in the conversation, ask what they need, and let them know which authorities apply to you. Managers are often unaware of the authorities; HR knows them.

## Direct Hire and Where the Rules Bend

Congress and OPM have given DoD direct-hire authority for many acquisition positions, meaning agencies can hire without the traditional rating and ranking and without applying veterans' preference in the usual way (verify the current authorities and their scope). This cuts both ways for a veteran: the preference does not lift you, but the process is faster and the hiring manager's judgment matters more. Under direct hire, the translated resume and the personal contact are everything. Also watch for term and temporary appointments in acquisition offices (often two to four years, sometimes convertible), reemployed annuitant positions, and positions in the defense agencies and joint offices that are less visible than the services' announcements but hire the same skills.

## Four Entry Paths, Compared

The realistic ways a veteran enters the government acquisition workforce.

### Open competitive announcement with preference STANDARD

Apply on USAJOBS; preference applied at rating; certificate to the manager.

Slow, broad, works. The federal resume decides it.

### Special authority (VRA, 30 percent disabled, VEOA) FASTEST

A manager who wants you asks HR to use the authority; competition skipped or opened.

Requires the manager to know you. Requires you to know the authority.

### Developmental or intern program CLEANEST

Lower entry grade; automatic ladder; complete training; rotations.

Best for degreed veterans without acquisition experience.

**Direct hire** **MANAGER-DRIVEN**

No traditional rating; preference not applied as usual; speed and judgment.

Translation and contact are everything.

**WHAT SENIOR PMS DO DIFFERENTLY**

Government hiring managers who bring in veterans learn the special authorities and ask HR to use them, and they write announcements whose specialized experience a translated military record can meet.

Veterans who get hired write the federal resume against the announcement, attach every document, apply across series and offices including the less visible agencies, use the developmental programs when they fit, and find the hiring manager who will be watching for their name.

**BUILD ON THIS**

- **The DoD Contracting Enterprise** Where the 1102s work
- **Career Roadmap** The ladder once you are in
- **The Contractor Path** The other side of the choice

## Key Terms

### Occupational Series

The four-digit code that classifies a federal job by occupation (1102 is contracting, 0343 is management and program analysis, 0346 is logistics management). Determines qualification standards and career ladders.

### GS Grade

The General Schedule pay grade, 1 through 15, with steps within each. Most acquisition professionals enter between GS-7 and GS-12 and top out at GS-13 to GS-15; the Senior Executive Service sits above.

### Veterans' Preference

Statutory hiring preference for eligible veterans in competitive federal hiring: five points for most eligible veterans, ten for disabled veterans and certain others, applied to ratings and category rankings. Verify current rules.

### VRA

Veterans Recruitment Appointment: a special authority allowing agencies to appoint eligible veterans without competition to positions up to GS-11, converting to career status after two years of satisfactory service.

### VEOA

Veterans Employment Opportunities Act: allows preference-eligible and certain other veterans to apply for positions announced under merit promotion procedures that would otherwise be limited to current federal employees.

### 30 Percent or More Disabled Veteran Authority

A special appointing authority allowing non-competitive appointment of veterans with a service-connected disability rating of 30 percent or more.

### DAWIA

The Defense Acquisition Workforce Improvement Act: the law and system that defines acquisition career fields, certification requirements, and training for the DoD acquisition workforce. Restructured under Back-to-Basics into functional areas and tiers.

### Acquisition Workforce

The roughly 180,000 DoD civilians and military members in designated acquisition positions across contracting, program management, engineering, logistics, test, financial management, and other functional areas.

### Merit Promotion vs. Delegated Examining

Two federal hiring paths: merit promotion for current federal employees and those with special eligibility (including VEOA veterans); delegated examining (open to the public) where veterans' preference applies.

### Developmental Program

Structured entry programs (service acquisition intern programs, DoD-wide pathways, contracting intern programs) that hire at entry grades with automatic promotions and paid training to a target grade.

## Knowledge Check

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Which occupational series is the contracting workforce?

A. 0343

✓ B. 1102

C. 0346

D. 0801

### WHY

1102 contract specialists become contracting officers with a warrant.

What does a Veterans Recruitment Appointment allow?

A. Ten extra points

✓ B. Non-competitive appointment of an eligible veteran to positions up to GS-11, converting to career status after two years

C. A guaranteed interview

D. Appointment at any grade

### WHY

One of several special authorities a hiring manager can use to bring you in without full competition.

What does VEOA let a veteran do?

A. Skip the security clearance

✓ B. Apply to merit promotion announcements otherwise limited to current federal employees

C. Enter at GS-13

D. Waive the education requirement

### WHY

It opens the internal announcements, not the preference points.

**How does HR read a USAJOBS application?**

A. As a job description

✓ **B. As a screening instrument: checking the resume against the qualification standard, the specialized experience statement, and the questionnaire, in the announcement's words**

C. By rank

D. By awards

**WHY**

A resume that does not use the announcement's language is rated ineligible.

**How long is a federal resume, typically?**

A. One page

B. Two pages

✓ **C. Three to five pages, mirrored to the announcement**

D. Ten pages

**WHY**

Detailed, with dates, hours per week, supervisors, and the announcement's duty language.

**What happens if a required document (DD-214, SF-15, transcript) is missing?**

A. HR requests it

✓ **B. Automatic rejection**

C. Nothing

D. The application is held

**WHY**

Attach everything the announcement asks for.

**What does DAWIA certification require?**

A. A security clearance

✓ **B. Specified DAU training, experience in the functional area, and in some areas an education or credential requirement, within a set period after entering the position**

C. A master's degree

D. A PMP

**WHY**

Paid for and on government time; a portable credential contractors also recognize.

**The most common experienced entry grade for veterans into acquisition is:**

A. GS-7

B. GS-9

✓ **C. GS-12**

D. GS-15

**WHY**

GS-11 is the VRA ceiling and a common first grade; GS-12 is the journeyman level.

**What do developmental and intern programs offer?**

A. High entry grades

✓ **B. Lower entry grades with an automatic promotion ladder, complete paid training, and rotations**

C. No training

D. Contractor placement

**WHY**

The cleanest entry for a degreed veteran without acquisition experience.

**Match the military background to the series:****CORRECT MATCHES**

|                         |                                         |
|-------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| Logistics and supply    | 0346 Logistics Management Specialist    |
| Finance and comptroller | 0501 / 0560 Financial and Budget        |
| Contracting specialty   | 1102 Contract Specialist                |
| Operations and planning | 0343 / 0301 Program Analyst and Program |

**WHY**

Logistics to 0346; finance to 0501/0560; contracting to 1102; operations to 0343/0301.

**Order a federal application:****CORRECT ORDER**

1. Identify the announcement type and which authorities apply to you
2. Write the federal resume mirrored to the specialized experience statement
3. Answer the questionnaire at the highest honest level
4. Attach DD-214, SF-15 and VA letter if applicable, and transcripts
5. Contact the hiring office and let them know which authorities apply

**WHY**

Identify the announcement type, build the mirrored resume, answer the questionnaire, attach documents, then work the hiring manager.

**Under direct-hire authority, what changes for a veteran?**

A. Preference points count double

**✓ B. Preference is not applied in the usual way; speed and the hiring manager's judgment matter more, so translation and contact are everything**

C. Veterans are excluded

D. Nothing

**WHY**

Verify the current authorities; they cut both ways.

## VETERAN TRANSITION: FROM UNIFORM TO ACQUISITION · LESSON 3

# The Contractor Path: Roles, Billability, and What a Defense Contractor Is Actually Buying When It Hires You

22 min

*How the contractor side hires veterans and why: the roles (program manager, deputy PM, capture and business development, operations, field service, contracts, logistics, analyst), what billability means and why it shapes your job security, how contractors value clearances and customer knowledge, compensation structure and how to read an offer, SkillBridge with contractors, and the questions to ask before accepting.*

## What a Contractor Is Buying

When a defense contractor hires a veteran for a billable role, it is buying something it can sell to the government: a person who meets a labor category's qualifications, holds the clearance the position requires, and brings customer credibility that helps win and keep the work. The company recovers your salary and more from the contract. This is the fundamental difference from a government job, and it explains almost everything about contractor employment: why hiring is fast (there is a position to fill and revenue to earn), why offers are sometimes contingent (the contract is not won yet), why your job is tied to a contract (when it ends or is lost, so is the position unless the company has another for you), and why the company cares about your clearance and your customer relationships at least as much as your skills. Understanding this makes you a better employee and a better negotiator.

## Contractor Roles That Hire Veterans

| ROLE                                                        | WHAT IT DOES                                                     | MILITARY BACKGROUND                                                                  | BILLABLE?                             |
|-------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| Program manager / deputy PM                                 | Runs the contract: staff, deliverables, customer, cost, schedule | Operations and leadership roles; company-grade and field-grade officers; senior NCOs | Yes, usually a key personnel position |
| Task lead / site lead                                       | Leads a team on one task or site                                 | NCOs and junior officers                                                             | Yes                                   |
| Analyst (operations, logistics, intelligence, requirements) | Supports a government office with analysis and products          | Staff roles in the matching domain                                                   | Yes                                   |
| Field service representative                                | Supports equipment with the unit, often deployed                 | Maintenance and technical specialties                                                | Yes                                   |
| Logistics / supply chain                                    | Sustainment, property, supply support to programs                | Logistics and supply                                                                 | Yes                                   |
| Capture / business development                              | Positions the company to win contracts                           | Anyone with deep customer knowledge; often after a billable role                     | No; overhead, funded by wins          |
| Contracts / subcontracts administrator                      | Manages the company's contracts and subcontracts                 | Contracting specialties                                                              | Partly; often overhead                |
| Trainer / instructor                                        | Delivers training under a contract                               | Instructors, drill sergeants, schoolhouse cadre                                      | Yes                                   |

## Billability, Explained Simply

A contractor employee is either charged to a customer contract (billable) or to the company's overhead (unbillable). The business module explains the economics; the version that matters to you is that a billable employee earns the company revenue every hour, and an unbillable one costs it money every hour. Companies therefore keep the bench small: if your contract ends and there is no other position for you within weeks, the company will usually let you go, however well you performed. This is not personal, and good companies work hard to place people; it is the structure. Your protection is being valuable on more than one contract, holding a clearance and skills that fit many labor categories, and knowing the company's pipeline well enough to see the next position coming.

**EXAMPLE (ILLUSTRATIVE)**

A 40-person services contractor bills an analyst to a customer contract at a hypothetical \$120 per hour. At 160 hours a month, that analyst brings in  $160 \times \$120 = \$19,200$  of revenue a month. That covers the analyst's salary and benefits plus a share of the company's overhead and margin. Then the contract ends and no other position is open. The analyst now charges to overhead. If salary and benefits cost the company a hypothetical \$11,000 a month, the company loses that \$11,000 every month the analyst sits on the bench, with no revenue against it. Six weeks without a placement costs about  $1.5 \times \$11,000 = \$16,500$ . This is why the bench stays small, and why an analyst whose clearance and skills fit several labor categories gets placed first.

## Reading an Offer

Contractor offers vary far more than government offers, and the base salary is only part of it. Look at the retirement match (four to six percent is common; some are far lower), the health plan cost to you, the paid leave (some companies bundle vacation and sick leave, some give less than the government), the bonus structure and whether it is actually paid, any deployment or hazard premiums, and the clearance premium if any. Check whether the offer is contingent on a contract award or on customer approval, and what happens if the contingency fails. Ask which labor category you will fill and whether your resume meets its qualifications without stretching, because a mismatch can be found in an audit. Ask about the contract's period of performance and when the recompetes is due, because that is your job's expiration date. A company that answers these directly is one to work for.

## Questions to Ask Before Accepting

- **Is this offer contingent, and on what?** A contract award, a customer approval, a clearance transfer. What is the timeline and the fallback.
- **Which contract and labor category?** Confirm you meet the qualifications as written.
- **When does the contract end and when is the recompetes?** Your position's horizon. Ask about the company's win rate on recompetes.
- **What is the total compensation?** Match, health cost, leave, bonus history, premiums.
- **What happens if the contract ends or is lost?** How the company has handled it before; how large the bench is; how long people stay on it.
- **Who is the customer, and what do they think of the company?** Ask around the customer side too; the answer predicts your daily life.
- **Is there a path off the contract?** Into capture, into management, onto other programs. Or is this role the whole relationship.

**KNOW WHAT YOUR CLEARANCE IS WORTH**

Your clearance and your customer relationships are worth real money to a contractor, and a good recruiter knows it before you do. This does not mean you should be cynical; it means you should know your value and negotiate from it. The company that hires you for a key personnel position on a contract it needs to win is getting something it could not get elsewhere. Ask for the compensation that reflects it, in writing, and understand that the relationship is a business one on both sides. Loyalty is earned, not assumed, in both directions.

One sentence to teach your team: **a contractor hires you to sell your qualifications, clearance, and customer credibility to the government on a specific contract, which is why hiring is fast, offers can be contingent, the job lives and dies with the contract, and your security comes from being valuable on more than one of them.**

**INTERMEDIATE****How Contractors Value Clearances and Customer Knowledge**

A cleared employee can be placed on cleared contracts immediately; an uncleared one waits months or years for a clearance the company must sponsor, and many contracts require the clearance before you can start. That difference shows up as a salary premium (varying by level and market, often meaningful at the higher levels), as faster hiring, and as more options. Customer knowledge is valued differently: it is not a line item, but it decides who becomes key personnel, who gets pulled into capture, and who the customer asks for by name at the recompetes. A veteran who served in the unit or command the contract supports is, to the contractor, a competitive advantage in the next competition. Understand that, and understand the ethics rules that limit how it can be used (the ethics lesson in this module), because the line between customer knowledge and improper use of inside information is real.

**SkillBridge With a Contractor**

SkillBridge lets you spend up to your last 180 days of service in an approved industry program while still drawing military pay (verify current rules and your command's approval process). Contractors use it as an extended interview: you work on a program, the team sees you, and the offer follows separation. The best SkillBridge positions are on contracts with an open or upcoming labor category you would fill, with a company that has placed previous SkillBridge participants, in a location you intend to live. Ask the company what percentage of its SkillBridge participants it has hired and where they are now. Be aware that during SkillBridge you are still a service member and the ethics rules apply: you cannot work on matters involving your own unit's procurements, and the company should know that.

## Large Primes, Mid-Sized Firms, and Small Businesses

The contractor world spans companies of a few people to over a hundred thousand, and the experience differs. Large primes offer structure, benefits, training, many contracts to move between, and a bench that can carry you between positions; they also move slowly, pay by band, and can treat a billable employee as a labor category. Mid-sized firms offer more visibility and faster advancement with less cushion. Small businesses (including veteran-owned ones) offer the most responsibility, the closest relationship with leadership, often equity or profit sharing, and the least protection when a contract ends; they are also where a veteran with customer knowledge can become a partner or an owner. The small business module explains the set-aside programs that make small firms viable. Match the company size to what you want and to your tolerance for risk.

## The Recompete and Your Position

Most service contracts are recompeted every three to five years. When the incumbent loses, the winner usually needs the same people (the contract often requires offering employment to qualified incumbent staff under labor rules for service contracts, and the winner wants continuity), so many employees transfer to the new company with a new offer. When the incumbent wins, positions continue. Either way, the recompete is when your value is reassessed and your compensation can change. Know the date. Know the competitors. Keep your resume current and your relationships on the customer side strong, because the customer's opinion of you follows you across companies.

### ADVANCED

## Moving Off the Contract: Capture, Management, and Ownership

The billable role is the entry, not the ceiling. Veterans who understand the customer move into capture and business development, where their knowledge of how the customer thinks shapes bids; the capture module explains the work. Others move into program management over several contracts, then into operations leadership. Some start companies, using the veteran-owned set-asides and the customer relationships to win the first contracts; the veteran business lesson in this module covers it. Each move takes you from billable to overhead or to owner, and each changes the economics: capture and management are funded by the company's wins and margins, so your value becomes the revenue you help produce rather than the hours you bill. Plan the move deliberately. A veteran who bills for fifteen years on the same contract has a stable job and a narrow future.

## Compensation Mechanics: What the Company Can Pay

The business module's billable hour lesson explains where your salary sits inside a billing rate. The practical consequence: your salary is bounded by the rate the contract pays for your labor category, less the company's indirect costs and margin. A company cannot pay you more than the category supports without

losing money on you, and it will not for long. When negotiating, it helps to know roughly what the category bills (contract rates are often visible on GSA schedules and in award data) and what the company's wrap rate is; a request that fits inside the rate is easy to grant and one that does not is impossible regardless of your value. On cost-type contracts, your salary is also subject to government reasonableness review. The room to negotiate is usually in the non-salary parts, in the labor category you are mapped to, and in the position (key personnel commands more).

## A Veteran's First Five Contractor Years, One Pattern

A common arc, not the only one.

### Year 1: Billable on a contract supporting your former community **ENTER**

Key personnel or task lead; learn the contract, the company, and the customer from the other side.

Do the job well; learn the company's pipeline; keep the clearance active.

### Years 2 to 3: Second contract or expanded role **WIDEN**

Deputy PM or PM; a second program; visible to the customer and to the company's capture team.

Value on more than one contract is your job security.

### Years 3 to 4: Capture involvement **SHAPE**

Contribute customer insight to bids; learn how the company wins; understand the ethics limits.

The move from billing hours to producing revenue.

### Year 5: Choose **DECIDE**

Operations leadership, full-time capture, a move to government, or starting a company.

Each is a real path. Choosing none of them is also a choice.

## WHAT SENIOR PMS DO DIFFERENTLY

Contractor leaders who retain veterans place them where their customer knowledge matters, tell them the contract's horizon honestly, and build them a path off the contract. Veterans who succeed on the contractor side know what the company is buying, read the offer beyond base salary, confirm the labor category fit, learn the recompete date, stay valuable across contracts, keep the customer relationship strong, and plan the move from billing hours to producing revenue.

## BUILD ON THIS

- **Unit Economics of a Billable Hour** Where your salary sits in the rate
- **The BD-to-Capture Lifecycle** The role customer knowledge feeds
- **Post-Government Employment Rules** The limits on using what you know

## Key Terms

### Billable

Charged directly to a customer contract. A billable employee's salary is recovered from contract revenue; an unbillable one is overhead. Most contractor jobs offered to veterans are billable.

### Utilization

The share of an employee's paid hours charged to contracts. Contractors target high utilization for billable staff; low utilization is a warning sign for the employee's position.

### Contingent Offer

A job offer conditioned on the contractor winning a contract or on the customer approving you for a position. Common in defense; the job may not exist yet.

### Key Personnel

Named positions in a contract whose incumbents the government must approve and whose replacement requires consent. Often filled by veterans with customer credibility.

### Labor Category

A defined role in a contract with qualification requirements (education, years of experience, clearance) and a billing rate. Your resume must fit the category to be billable on it.

### Bench

Employees not currently billable, carried on overhead while awaiting assignment. Companies keep benches small and briefly.

### Capture

The work of positioning to win a specific contract before the solicitation is released: customer relationships, teaming, solution shaping. A role where military customer knowledge is directly valuable.

### Field Service Representative

A contractor employee deployed with or embedded in a military unit to support equipment. A common first contractor role for maintenance and technical veterans.

### Total Compensation

Base salary plus bonus, retirement match, health, leave, and any clearance or deployment premiums. Contractor offers vary widely in the non-salary parts.

### Recompete

The competition for the follow-on to an existing contract. When the incumbent loses, its billable employees usually transfer to the winner or lose their positions.

## Knowledge Check

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What is a contractor buying when it hires a veteran for a billable role?

- A. Rank
- ✓ B. A person who meets a labor category, holds the required clearance, and brings customer credibility, whose salary is recovered from contract revenue

- C. A trainee
- D. A government contact

### WHY

This explains fast hiring, contingent offers, and contract-tied jobs.

What does billable mean?

- A. Paid hourly
- ✓ B. Charged directly to a customer contract, so the employee earns the company revenue

- C. Eligible for bonus
- D. On the bench

### WHY

Unbillable employees are overhead; companies keep the bench small.

What is a contingent offer?

- A. A part-time offer
- ✓ B. An offer conditioned on a contract award or customer approval; the job may not exist yet

- C. An offer with a signing bonus
- D. A government offer

### WHY

Ask about the timeline and the fallback.

**Why does the recomplete date matter to an employee?**

A. It sets the bonus

✓ **B. It is the position's horizon; the job continues or transfers depending on who wins**

C. It triggers a raise

D. It does not matter

**WHY**

Know the date, the competitors, and keep the customer relationship strong.

**Which role is typically not billable?**

A. Field service representative

B. Task lead

✓ **C. Capture and business development**

D. Analyst

**WHY**

Capture is overhead funded by wins; the move from billing hours to producing revenue.

**Why must your resume match the labor category?**

A. For the bonus

✓ **B. Because a mismatch between the category's qualifications and your record can be found in an audit**

C. For the clearance

D. It does not need to

**WHY**

Confirm you meet the qualifications as written before accepting.

**What should you ask a company about its SkillBridge program?**

A. The uniform policy

✓ **B. What percentage of participants it has hired and where they are now**

C. Whether it pays extra

D. Whether the clearance transfers

**WHY**

SkillBridge is an extended interview; the hiring record tells you what it leads to.

**What bounds the salary a contractor can pay you?**

A. Your rank

✓ **B. The billing rate for your labor category, less the company's indirect costs and margin**

C. The government pay scale

D. The clearance level only

**WHY**

Negotiating room is often in non-salary parts, the category mapping, and the position.

**What is the main trade-off of working for a small business versus a large prime?**

A. Small businesses pay less always

✓ **B. More responsibility, visibility, and ownership potential, with less protection when a contract ends**

C. Large primes have no benefits

D. Small businesses cannot hold clearances

**WHY**

Match the size to what you want and your tolerance for risk.

**Match the military background to the contractor role:****CORRECT MATCHES**

|                                                |                                   |
|------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| Maintenance and technical specialty            | Field service representative      |
| Operations and leadership roles                | Program manager or deputy PM      |
| Instructor or schoolhouse cadre                | Trainer under a training contract |
| Deep customer knowledge, after a billable role | Capture and business development  |

**WHY**

Maintenance to field service; operations leaders to PM; instructors to training; deep customer knowledge to capture.

**Order the questions to resolve before accepting a contractor offer:****CORRECT ORDER**

1. Is the offer contingent, and on what?
2. Which contract and labor category, and do I meet its qualifications?
3. When does the contract end and when is the recompetete?
4. What is the total compensation beyond base salary?
5. Is there a path off this contract into capture, management, or other programs?

**WHY**

Contingency, contract and category fit, horizon, total compensation, then the path forward.

**What is the risk of billing on the same contract for fifteen years?**

A. Losing the clearance

✓ **B. A stable job and a narrow future; the billable role is the entry, not the ceiling**

C. Being audited

D. Losing veterans' preference

**WHY**

Plan the move to capture, management, government, or ownership deliberately.

## VETERAN TRANSITION: FROM UNIFORM TO ACQUISITION · LESSON 4

# Your Clearance Is an Asset: Keeping It, Transferring It, and Knowing What It Is Worth

18 min

*How a security clearance works after you leave service: the difference between eligibility and access, the two-year window before a clearance lapses and how to stay inside it, reciprocity and transferring to a new employer or agency, continuous vetting and what it watches, what employers can ask and what you should never claim, the salary premium and where it is largest, and the mistakes that cost veterans their clearances during transition.*

## Why This Lesson Exists

Your clearance may be the single most valuable professional asset you carry out of the service, and it is the one veterans most often damage in transition, usually without knowing. It lapses quietly if you spend too long between sponsors. It gets flagged by financial trouble during a job gap. It gets complicated by a foreign spouse, foreign travel, or a foreign employer taken on to bridge income. It gets misrepresented on a resume in ways that are easy to check. And it gets undervalued in salary negotiations by people who do not know what it is worth. This lesson is the maintenance manual.

## Eligibility and Access, and What Happens When You Separate

Your clearance has two parts. Eligibility is the adjudicated decision that you may hold a clearance at a level (secret, top secret, with or without additional accesses). Access is being read on to information by an organization that needs you to have it. When you leave the service, your access ends (you are debriefed), but your eligibility remains in the system of record for a period. A new employer with a cleared facility and a need can request that eligibility be reinstated and grant you access, usually without a new investigation, if you are still inside the window and nothing has changed. The window is the whole game: the commonly cited rule is that eligibility can be reinstated within two years of your last access, and that after that a new investigation is required (verify the current policy, which has been adjusted with continuous vetting). A veteran who takes a year to find a cleared job has used half the window.

### IN PLAIN TERMS

Picture a driver's license and the keys to a company car. Eligibility is the license: the decision that you may drive. Access is the keys to one specific car, handed over by an employer that needs you behind the wheel. When you leave the service, you hand back the keys, but the license stays on file. The catch is that this license quietly lapses if nobody hands you keys again within the window, and then you retake the whole test, which here means a new investigation.

## Keeping the Clearance Alive Through Transition

- **Know your investigation date and level** Get them from your security manager before you leave; write them down. Employers will ask.
- **Know your debrief date** The window runs from your last access. Confirm the date on your separation paperwork.
- **Get a sponsor inside the window** A cleared job, a SkillBridge with a cleared contractor, a reserve or Guard billet that maintains access, or a government position. Any of them keeps eligibility active.
- **Consider the reserve component** A drilling reserve position that requires a clearance keeps it current while you transition. Many veterans use this deliberately.
- **Keep your finances stable** A job gap that produces missed payments is the most common flag in continuous vetting.
- **Self-report what needs reporting** Foreign travel, foreign contacts, and financial events, to whichever security office holds you at the time.
- **Do not take a foreign employer or contract to bridge income without advice** Foreign employment and foreign business interests are adjudicative issues; some are manageable if reported, some are not.

### EXAMPLE (ILLUSTRATIVE)

A veteran with Top Secret eligibility is debriefed when she separates in March. Using the commonly cited two-year reinstatement window (verify current policy), she has 24 months to find a cleared sponsor. Her job search takes 10 months, so she has used 10 of 24 months and has  $24 - 10 = 14$  left. During the gap, one card payment is late. She keeps a record of it and of her repayment plan, logs her one foreign trip, and tells the contractor's facility security officer (FSO) about both before the reinstatement request goes in. Because she is inside the window and nothing is hidden, reinstatement goes ahead without a new investigation. Her resume states the clearance exactly: "Top Secret eligibility, last investigation 2024, out of access since separation in March."

## What Employers Can Ask, and What You Should Never Claim

An employer can ask whether you hold a clearance, at what level, when it was adjudicated, and by which agency; they can verify all of it through their FSO once they sponsor you. They cannot see the details of your investigation. On a resume or in an interview, state the level and the date of the last investigation accurately. Never claim a clearance you do not hold, never claim it is active when you have been out of access, never inflate the level, and never list accesses (special programs) that should not be named in an unclassified document. Misrepresenting a clearance is checked routinely and ends candidacies and clearances both. The honest statement "Top Secret eligibility, last investigation 2024, out of access since separation in March" is exactly what a recruiter wants to see.

### CLEARANCES FAIL THROUGH NEGLECT, NOT DRAMA

The most common way a veteran loses a clearance in transition is not a dramatic event. It is a slow job search, a few missed payments, a foreign trip not reported because there was no security office to report it to, and then a new employer's FSO submitting the reinstatement request and getting a flag. Every one of those is avoidable with a calendar, a budget, and the habit of reporting. Treat the clearance like the professional credential it is: it has maintenance requirements, and neglect is the way it fails.

## The Clearance in Numbers

### 2 years

Commonly cited  
reinstatement window  
after last access  
Verify current policy

### Months to a year+

Time for a new  
investigation if it lapses  
Longer at higher levels

### Meaningful

Salary premium for  
cleared roles  
Largest at TS and above and  
in hot markets

### 13

Adjudicative guideline  
categories  
Financial and foreign  
influence are the frequent  
ones

One sentence to teach your team: **your eligibility survives separation for a limited window, a new sponsor inside that window reinstates it without a new investigation, and the things that break it in transition are a long gap, financial trouble, unreported foreign contact, and overstating it on a resume.**

### INTERMEDIATE

## Reciprocity: How Transfers Actually Work

Policy says an existing eligibility at a level should be accepted by any agency without a new investigation. In practice, transfers between DoD components and DoD contractors are routine and fast (the FSO submits a request in the system of record, and access is granted in days to weeks). Transfers between DoD and other agencies (the intelligence community, the Department of Energy, and others) work in principle but may involve additional requirements for particular accesses, a polygraph for some positions, or a review of the existing investigation's scope. A clearance from a non-DoD agency coming into DoD is similar in reverse. When a transfer stalls, it is usually because the new organization requires something the old investigation did not include, or because a self-reported event needs adjudication. Ask the new employer's FSO, before you accept, whether they foresee any issue with your specific clearance, agency, and date.

## Continuous Vetting and What It Watches

Periodic reinvestigations every five or ten years have largely been replaced by continuous vetting: automated checks of financial records, criminal records, foreign travel, and other data sources, running as

long as you are enrolled. A flag is sent to your sponsoring security office, which may ask you about it; most flags are resolved with an explanation and documentation. The categories that generate the most flags are financial (delinquencies, collections, bankruptcies, large unexplained deposits) and foreign influence (travel, contacts, property, employment). Continuous vetting is not a trap; it is a system that rewards people who report things themselves before the system finds them. A self-reported financial hardship with a plan is a manageable issue. The same hardship discovered by the system and never reported is a personal conduct issue on top of a financial one.

## Transition Events and Their Clearance Implications

| EVENT                                       | IMPLICATION                                                                    | WHAT TO DO                                                                |
|---------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Job gap of several months                   | Uses the reinstatement window; financial strain risk                           | Budget the gap; consider a reserve billet; keep looking inside the window |
| Foreign spouse or partner                   | Foreign influence guideline; manageable and common                             | Reported on the SF-86; keep documentation; expect questions               |
| Foreign travel                              | Reportable; unreported travel is the problem                                   | Report to whichever security office holds you; keep a log                 |
| Foreign employer or client to bridge income | Foreign preference and influence issues; can be serious                        | Get advice before accepting; some are disqualifying                       |
| Starting a business                         | Foreign clients, investors, or partners raise flags; domestic business is fine | Report business interests as required; screen foreign ties                |
| Financial difficulty                        | The most common flag                                                           | Report it; show a plan; keep records of payments                          |
| Reserve or Guard service                    | Maintains access and eligibility                                               | A deliberate strategy for many transitioning veterans                     |

## What the Clearance Is Worth, and Where

Cleared roles pay more than equivalent uncleared roles because the supply of cleared people is limited and the time to clear a new hire is long. The premium varies with level (secret modest, top secret larger, top secret with additional accesses and a polygraph largest), with location (concentrated near the cleared work: the national capital region, certain installations and agencies), and with the market at the moment. Contractors price it into salary and sometimes into a signing bonus; government positions do not pay a premium but restrict cleared positions to cleared people, which is its own advantage. When negotiating, name the level and the date, note that no sponsorship or investigation wait is needed, and let the recruiter do the arithmetic; they know what it saves them.

**ADVANCED**

## Adjudication After Transition: When an Issue Arises

If a reinstatement request or a continuous vetting flag produces an issue, the process is a request for information or an interview, a possible statement of reasons proposing to deny or revoke, a written response, and an appeal path (through a hearing for contractor personnel under the industrial security program, or an agency process for government employees). The adjudicative guidelines include mitigating conditions for each category: for financial issues, that the problem was beyond your control and you acted responsibly, or that you are on a documented repayment plan; for foreign influence, that the contacts are casual, reported, and unlikely to create pressure. Cases are decided on the whole person. Veterans facing a statement of reasons should respond thoroughly and on time, with documentation, and should consider counsel experienced in clearance cases; the response is the decision.

## The Ethics Edge: Clearance, Customer Knowledge, and What Stays Behind

A clearance lets a new employer read you on to information; it does not let you bring information with you. Classified information, controlled unclassified information, source selection information, contractor proposal information, and non-public program details from your service stay with the government. Contractors sometimes assume a veteran arrives with useful inside knowledge of programs, budgets, and competitors, and some veterans assume it is theirs to share. It is not. The procurement integrity rules and the post-government employment rules covered in the next lesson draw the lines, and the clearance rules add the classified layer. The customer knowledge that is legitimately yours is how the organization works, what it values, how it makes decisions, and who does what. What it is buying, from whom, for how much, and what it thinks of the competitors is not.

## The Clearance Transition Checklist

Actions by phase.

### Six months before separation **PREPARE**

Confirm level, investigation date, and adjudicating agency; get copies of your last SF-86 submission if possible; identify cleared employers and SkillBridge options.

Consistency between SF-86 submissions matters; keep what you submitted.

### At separation **RECORD**

Note the debrief date; understand the window; decide on a reserve billet if it fits.

The window runs from the debrief.

**During the search** MAINTAIN

Keep finances stable; log foreign travel and contacts; state the clearance accurately; ask each employer's FSO about transfer issues.

Report to the security office that holds you; if none does, keep the log for the next one.

**At the new employer** REACTIVATE

Meet the FSO on day one; complete the reinstatement or transfer; report anything from the gap; enroll in continuous vetting.

Anything unreported from the gap gets reported now, with context.

**WHAT SENIOR PMS DO DIFFERENTLY**

Security officers who help veterans transition brief them on the window and the reporting obligations before separation and are reachable afterward. Veterans who keep their clearances know their dates, find a sponsor inside the window, keep their finances and foreign contacts reported, state the clearance exactly, ask the new FSO about transfer issues before accepting, and understand that the clearance lets them be read on to information but never lets them bring it with them.

**BUILD ON THIS**

- **Facility and Personnel Security** Clearances from the company's side
- **CUI, FCI, and Classified** What stays behind
- **Post-Government Employment Rules** The lines on customer knowledge

## Key Terms

### Eligibility vs. Access

Eligibility is the adjudicated determination that you may hold a clearance at a level; access is being read on to specific information by an employer with a need. You can be eligible without access, and access ends when the need does.

### Lapse

The point at which eligibility can no longer be reinstated without a new investigation, generally after a period out of access (commonly cited as two years; verify current policy). Inside the window, a new sponsor can usually reinstate it.

### Reciprocity

The policy that an existing clearance at a level, adjudicated by one agency, should be accepted by another without a new investigation, subject to exceptions. Works in principle; varies in practice.

### Continuous Vetting

Automated, ongoing checks of records (financial, criminal, travel, and others) that have replaced periodic reinvestigations for most cleared people. Flags go to the sponsoring security office.

### Sponsor

The employer or agency that holds your clearance in the system and has a need for you to have access. Without a sponsor, you have eligibility but no active access.

### DISS / NBIS

The DoD systems of record for clearance eligibility and access (DISS, transitioning to NBIS; verify current). Your facility security officer works in them.

### Facility Security Officer (FSO)

The person at a cleared contractor responsible for the facility clearance and for employees' personnel clearances. Your first call at a new employer.

### SF-86 / eApp

The personnel security questionnaire. Everything you put on it is checked; inconsistencies between submissions are themselves a finding.

### Self-Reporting

The obligation to report to your security office events that could affect eligibility: foreign contacts, foreign travel, financial problems, arrests, and others. Failing to report is often worse than the event.

### Adjudicative Guidelines

The thirteen categories (financial, foreign influence, personal conduct, drug involvement, and others) against which eligibility is judged. Verify the current guidelines.

## Knowledge Check

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What is the difference between eligibility and access?

A. None

✓ **B. Eligibility is the adjudicated determination you may hold a clearance; access is being read on by a sponsor with a need, and it ends when the need does**

C. Access is higher than eligibility

D. Eligibility requires a polygraph

### WHY

On separation your access ends; eligibility remains in the system for a window.

What happens to eligibility after separation?

A. It is revoked immediately

✓ **B. It remains for a window (commonly cited as two years from last access) during which a new sponsor can reinstate it without a new investigation**

C. It becomes permanent

D. It transfers automatically to any employer

### WHY

Verify current policy; a slow job search uses the window.

What is the most common clearance flag during a transition?

A. Foreign travel

✓ **B. Financial trouble from a job gap**

C. Changing address

D. Starting school

### WHY

Budget the gap; self-report with a plan if problems arise.

**How should a clearance appear on a resume?**

A. Level, agency, and special accesses by name

✓ **B. Level and date of last investigation, accurately, with out-of-access status if applicable; never accesses that should not appear unclassified**

C. Just "cleared"

D. It should not appear

**WHY**

Misrepresentation is routinely checked and ends candidacies and clearances.

**What does a reserve or Guard billet requiring a clearance do for a transitioning veteran?**

A. Nothing

✓ **B. Maintains access and eligibility while the civilian search continues**

C. Doubles the salary premium

D. Prevents contractor employment

**WHY**

A deliberate strategy many veterans use.

**What replaced periodic reinvestigations for most cleared people?**

A. Annual polygraphs

✓ **B. Continuous vetting: automated ongoing checks of financial, criminal, travel, and other records**

C. Nothing

D. Employer interviews

**WHY**

It rewards self-reporting before the system finds the event.

**Why should you ask a new employer's FSO about transfer issues before accepting?**

A. To negotiate salary

✓ **B. Because transfers between agencies or for particular accesses may require additional steps, and a stalled transfer can delay or void a contingent offer**

C. It is required by law

D. To get a signing bonus

**WHY**

DoD-to-DoD is routine; cross-agency and special-access transfers vary.

**Taking a foreign employer or client to bridge income during transition is:**

A. Always fine

✓ **B. A foreign preference and influence issue that can be serious; get advice before accepting and report it**

C. Required to be disclosed only after reinstatement

D. Prohibited

**WHY**

Some are manageable if reported; some are disqualifying.

**Where is the clearance salary premium largest?**

A. Secret, everywhere

✓ **B. Top secret with additional accesses and a polygraph, near concentrated cleared work, in a hot market**

C. Government positions

D. Overseas

**WHY**

Contractors price it into salary; government restricts cleared positions to cleared people instead.

**Match the event to the right action:****CORRECT MATCHES**

|                               |                                                          |
|-------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Foreign travel during the gap | Log it and report to whichever security office holds you |
| Financial difficulty          | Report it with a plan; keep payment records              |
| Offer from a foreign client   | Get advice before accepting; some are disqualifying      |
| Long search expected          | Consider a reserve billet that keeps access current      |

**WHY**

Report, budget, get advice, and use the reserve component deliberately.

**Order the clearance transition checklist:****CORRECT ORDER**

1. Confirm level, investigation date, and agency; keep your SF-86 submission
2. Note the debrief date and understand the window
3. Keep finances stable and log foreign travel and contacts during the search
4. Ask each prospective employer's FSO about transfer issues
5. Meet the new FSO on day one; reinstate; report anything from the gap

**WHY**

Prepare before separation, record at separation, maintain during the search, reactivate at the new employer.

**What customer knowledge is legitimately yours to bring to a contractor?**

A. What the customer is buying, from whom, and for how much

✓ **B. How the organization works, what it values, how it decides, and who does what; not procurement, budget, or competitor details**

C. Everything you learned in service

D. Nothing

**WHY**

The clearance lets you be read on; it never lets you bring information with you.

## VETERAN TRANSITION: FROM UNIFORM TO ACQUISITION · LESSON 5

# Post-Government Employment Rules: The Revolving Door, Explained Without a Law Degree

24 min

*The rules that govern seeking and taking a job with a defense contractor before and after leaving the military or civil service: the Procurement Integrity Act restrictions on job talks and the one-year compensation ban, the lifetime and two-year representational bans under 18 U.S.C. 207, the one-year cooling-off for senior officials, the DoD ethics opinion letter requirement, who the rules apply to (and the enlisted exception), what counts as seeking employment, and how to stay clean with disclosure, disqualification, and an ethics opinion.*

## Why These Rules Exist, and Why They Are Not the Enemy

The revolving door rules exist because a person who is deciding a contract while interviewing with the bidder cannot be trusted to decide it fairly, and because a person who leaves a program office and immediately represents a contractor on that same program carries an unfair advantage and the appearance of one. The rules do not stop veterans from working for contractors; the defense industry is full of them, legitimately. They stop specific things: negotiating for a job while acting on a matter affecting the employer, switching sides on a matter you handled, and cashing in specific procurement roles too quickly. Every one of these has a clean path through it: disclose, disqualify, wait where required, and get it in writing. The veterans who get in trouble are almost always the ones who did not ask.

### IN PLAIN TERMS

Think of a referee who is interviewing for a coaching job with one of the teams. He can keep refereeing, but not that team's games while the interviews are going on. Once he retires, he can coach for that team. What he can never do is walk back onto the field and argue the calls on a game he refereed himself. The revolving door rules work the same way: step back from matters affecting a company you are talking to, and never switch sides on a matter you worked.

## While You Are Still Serving: Seeking Employment

The moment you send a resume to a company, respond to a recruiter with anything other than no, or begin discussing terms, you are seeking employment with that company under the ethics rules. From that moment, you may not participate in any particular matter that affects that company's financial interests: evaluating its proposal, administering its contract, recommending an award, approving its invoices, writing a requirement it will bid on. The remedy is disqualification: a written notice to your supervisor and ethics

counselor that you are seeking employment with the company and are withdrawing from matters affecting it. Under the Procurement Integrity Act, if you are participating in a procurement above the threshold and a bidder contacts you about employment, you must report the contact in writing and either reject the offer or disqualify yourself. Unreported contacts are the most common violation, and they are discovered in protests and investigations years later.

## The Disqualification Memo, in Practice

- **Trigger** You have sent a resume, engaged with a recruiter, or been approached and not rejected it. Not an offer; the first step.
- **To whom** Your supervisor and the ethics counselor (the legal office). Copy the contracting officer if you are on a contract team.
- **What it says** That you are seeking employment with [company], the date it began, and that you are disqualified from all particular matters affecting it until further notice.
- **What happens** Your work is reassigned for those matters. It is routine; supervisors deal with it constantly.
- **When it ends** When you reject the company or it rejects you, or two months after you last heard from them with no response. Reinstatement is also in writing.
- **The alternative** Do not engage with any company whose matters you are working until you leave those matters. Some people choose this to keep it simple.

## After You Leave: The Three Bans of 18 U.S.C. 207

The federal post-employment statute has three main provisions for most people. First, a lifetime ban: you may never represent anyone other than the United States to the government, with intent to influence, on a particular matter involving specific parties in which you participated personally and substantially. If you evaluated a proposal or administered a contract, you can never come back to the government as that contractor's representative on that contract. Second, a two-year ban on the same kind of representation for matters that were under your official responsibility in your last year, even if you did not personally work them. If you led a division, everything the division handled is covered for two years. Third, for senior officials (generally O-7 and above and civilian equivalents), a one-year ban on communicating with your former agency on behalf of anyone, on any matter, with intent to influence. Two things to note. These are representational bans: they restrict appearing before or communicating with the government, not working behind the scenes for the new employer. And 207 applies to officers and civilian employees; enlisted members are generally not covered by it (though the Procurement Integrity Act and the seeking-employment rules still apply to them). Verify your own situation with ethics counsel.

## The Rules at a Glance

| RULE                                        | WHO                                                                                  | WHAT IT RESTRICTS                                                                                   | HOW LONG                           |
|---------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------|
| Seeking employment (ethics regulation)      | Everyone                                                                             | Participating in matters affecting a company you are seeking employment with                        | While seeking; ends on rejection   |
| Procurement Integrity Act, reporting        | Anyone participating in a procurement above threshold                                | Must report employment contacts from bidders and reject or disqualify                               | During the procurement             |
| Procurement Integrity Act, compensation ban | COs, PMs, source selection roles, and certain approvers on contracts above threshold | Accepting compensation from that contractor                                                         | One year from the specified action |
| 207 lifetime ban                            | Officers and civilians                                                               | Representing others to the government on particular matters you personally and substantially worked | Forever                            |
| 207 two-year ban                            | Officers and civilians                                                               | Representing others on matters under your official responsibility in your last year                 | Two years                          |
| 207 one-year cooling-off                    | Senior officials (O-7+, SES, and equivalents)                                        | Communicating with your former agency on behalf of anyone, on anything                              | One year                           |
| DoD ethics opinion letter                   | Senior officials and acquisition officials on contracts above threshold              | Must obtain a written ethics opinion before accepting defense contractor compensation               | Two years after leaving            |

### THE PATH IS ALMOST ALWAYS OPEN. ASK IN WRITING.

The rules sound like they were written to keep you out of the industry. They were not. A contracting NCO who administered a contractor's task order can go work for that contractor the day after separation; what they cannot do is come back to the contracting office as the contractor's representative on that task order, ever, or disclose the source selection information they saw. A program manager who ran a source selection can work for the winner after the one-year compensation ban, and behind the scenes even sooner. The path is almost always open. The step everyone skips is asking the ethics counselor in writing, which takes a week and produces a letter you keep forever.

One sentence to teach your team: **disqualify yourself in writing the moment you start talking to a company whose matters you touch, never switch sides on a matter you worked, wait out the one-year compensation ban if you held a covered procurement role, and get an ethics opinion letter before you accept, because every path through the rules is open to someone who asks.**

**INTERMEDIATE**

## **The Procurement Integrity Act Compensation Ban**

If you served as the contracting officer, source selection authority, a member of the source selection evaluation board, chief of a technical or financial evaluation team, program manager, deputy program manager, or administrative contracting officer on a contract above the threshold (verify the current figure), or personally made certain decisions on it (awarding a contract, subcontract, or modification above the threshold, establishing overhead rates, approving payments, or settling claims above the threshold), you may not accept compensation from that contractor as an employee, officer, director, or consultant for one year after the specified action. Compensation from a division or affiliate that does not produce the same or similar products or services may be permitted with a written opinion. The ban is about that contractor, not the industry, and it runs from the date of your last covered action, which may be well before your separation date. Many veterans are already outside the year by the time they leave.

## **What You Can and Cannot Take With You**

Regardless of any employment rule, some information is protected by its nature. Source selection information and contractor bid or proposal information are protected by the Procurement Integrity Act; disclosing them, ever, to anyone not authorized, is a crime. Classified and controlled unclassified information stays with the government. Non-public information about programs, budgets, requirements in development, and government positions on negotiations is covered by the ethics rules on misuse of non-public information. What you can take: your skills, your understanding of how the organization works and decides, your professional relationships, and public information. The line a new employer will sometimes push is program insight that was not public; the answer is that you will help them understand the customer, and you will not tell them what the customer is planning to buy or what it thought of their last proposal.

## **The DoD Ethics Opinion Letter and the Section 847 Process**

DoD requires certain departing officials to obtain a written post-employment ethics opinion before accepting compensation from a defense contractor within two years of leaving: senior officials (O-7 and above, SES, and equivalents) and officials who served in acquisition positions or made decisions on contracts above the threshold (verify current criteria under the implementing rules, often called the Section 847 requirements after the defense bill that created them). The letter is requested from the ethics counselor, describes the prospective employment, and states which restrictions apply. The contractor is required to confirm the letter exists before hiring. Even for those not required to get one, an ethics opinion is free, fast, and the best protection available: a written statement from the government that your new job is consistent with the rules, on the facts you disclosed. Get one.

## Enlisted, Officers, and Civilians: Who Is Covered by What

The coverage differs, and the differences matter. The seeking-employment rules and the Procurement Integrity Act apply to everyone who participates in procurements, regardless of rank or status. The 18 U.S.C. 207 representational bans apply to officers and civilian employees but generally not to enlisted members. The senior official cooling-off applies to O-7 and above and civilian equivalents. The DoD ethics letter requirement applies by position and by contract role. Reservists and Guard members on active duty for more than a short period can be covered while serving. So a senior NCO who ran contracting for a command has Procurement Integrity Act obligations and no 207 bans; a captain who evaluated one proposal has a lifetime 207 ban on that one matter; a colonel who led a program office has two-year coverage of everything the office did. Ask the ethics counselor which apply to you; do not reason from a lesson.

### ADVANCED

## How Violations Actually Surface

Post-employment violations rarely surface at the time. They surface in a protest, when a losing bidder discovers that a former program official now works for the winner and argues that the award was tainted; in an investigation triggered by a complaint; in a False Claims Act case where the government looks at how a contractor gained an advantage; or in a security or suitability review years later. The consequences range from a disqualified award (the contractor loses the contract, and everyone remembers why) to civil penalties, to criminal prosecution for the Procurement Integrity Act and 207 in serious cases. Contractors that have been through it now screen new hires from government for these issues and ask for the ethics letter. The practical protection for a veteran is a file: the disqualification memos, the ethics opinion, and a record of what matters you worked, kept for as long as the bans run.

## Consulting, Advisory Boards, and Part-Time Arrangements

The rules do not distinguish between full-time employment and consulting: a consulting arrangement with a contractor is compensation for the Procurement Integrity Act and employment for the seeking-employment rules, and representing a client to the government is representation under 207. Advisory boards, retainers, speaking fees from contractors, and equity in a startup that sells to the government all count. Retired senior officers who take multiple board and advisory roles are the group most often caught by the cooling-off and the ethics letter requirement, because each new arrangement needs its own analysis. The rule of thumb: any arrangement where a defense contractor pays you, in any form, within two years of leaving, gets an ethics opinion first.

## Four Scenarios, Analyzed

How the rules apply in common transition situations. Illustrative; confirm your own with ethics counsel.

**Contract specialist joins the contractor whose orders she administered****USUALLY FINE**

Disqualify while interviewing. If she was the ACO or approved payments above the threshold, one-year compensation ban from that contractor. Afterward, she may work for them but never represent them to the government on those orders.

The lifetime ban is narrow; the job is available.

**Program manager wants to join the winner of his source selection****WAIT**

One-year Procurement Integrity Act ban from that contractor, running from the award. Lifetime 207 ban on representing them on that contract. Ethics letter required.

A different contractor, or the same one after the year, is open.

**Retired general takes an advisory board seat with a prime****CAREFUL**

One-year cooling-off on contacting the former agency on anything; two-year ethics letter requirement; two-year 207 ban on matters under official responsibility; possibly Procurement Integrity Act ban on specific contracts.

Each additional arrangement needs its own opinion.

**Senior NCO joins a small business as operations lead****FINE**

Seeking-employment disqualification while interviewing if any matters touch the company. No 207 coverage as enlisted. Procurement Integrity Act only if in a covered role on a covered contract.

Source selection information stays protected regardless.

**WHAT SENIOR PMS DO DIFFERENTLY**

Government leaders brief their people on the seeking-employment rules before the job search starts, treat disqualification memos as routine, and make the ethics counselor easy to reach. Veterans who stay clean disqualify in writing at the first contact, know which bans apply to them by rank and role, wait out the compensation ban where it applies, get an ethics opinion letter before accepting anything, keep the file, and never let a new employer talk them into sharing what stays behind.

**BUILD ON THIS**

- **Procurement Integrity and Ethics** The rules from the contractor's side
- **Source Selection** What source selection information is
- **Your Clearance Is an Asset** The classified layer of what stays behind

## Key Terms

### Procurement Integrity Act

41 U.S.C. chapter 21: restricts disclosure of source selection and bid information, requires officials participating in a procurement above a threshold to report contacts about employment with a bidder, and bars certain officials from accepting compensation from a contractor for one year after specified roles on contracts above a threshold. Verify current thresholds.

### Seeking Employment

Under the ethics rules, you are seeking employment from the moment you send a resume, respond to an unsolicited offer with anything other than rejection, or engage in negotiations, and the disqualification duty starts then.

### Disqualification (Recusal)

Withdrawing, in writing, from participation in any matter affecting a company with which you are seeking employment. The universal remedy for the conflict.

### 18 U.S.C. 207

The federal post-employment statute: a lifetime ban on representing anyone to the government on particular matters you participated in personally and substantially; a two-year ban on matters under your official responsibility; a one-year cooling-off for senior officials contacting their former agency. Applies to officers and civilian employees; enlisted members are generally not covered. Verify with ethics counsel.

### Particular Matter

A specific contract, proposal, claim, investigation, or similar matter involving specific parties. The unit of analysis for the 207 bans.

### Personal and Substantial Participation

Involvement through decision, approval, recommendation, advice, investigation, or similar action that is significant to the matter. Signing off, evaluating, or advising counts; a briefing you attended usually does not.

### Senior Official

For the one-year cooling-off, generally O-7 and above, SES, and civilians above a pay threshold. For the DoD ethics letter, also officials in specified acquisition roles. Verify current definitions.

### Ethics Opinion Letter

The written opinion, required under DoD-specific rules for certain officials (senior officials and acquisition officials on contracts above a threshold) before accepting compensation from a defense contractor within two years of leaving, and advisable for everyone else.

### Representational Ban

A prohibition on communicating with or appearing before the government on behalf of someone else with intent to influence. Behind-the-scenes work for the new employer is generally not barred by 207; representing the employer to the government on the covered matter is.

### Source Selection Information

Bid prices, proposal evaluations, rankings, source selection plans, and similar information, protected during a procurement and afterward. Disclosure is a crime regardless of employment.

## Knowledge Check

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When does "seeking employment" begin under the ethics rules?

- A. When you accept an offer
- ✓ B. When you send a resume, respond to a recruiter with anything other than rejection, or begin discussing terms
- C. When you separate
- D. When you sign a contract

### WHY

The disqualification duty starts at the first step, not at the offer.

What is the remedy while seeking employment with a company whose matters you work?

- A. Resign
- ✓ B. Written disqualification from all particular matters affecting that company, to your supervisor and ethics counselor
- C. Verbal notice to a colleague
- D. Nothing until an offer arrives

### WHY

Routine; supervisors reassign the work.

Under the Procurement Integrity Act, what must you do if a bidder contacts you about a job during a covered procurement?

- A. Ignore it
- ✓ B. Report the contact in writing and either reject the offer or disqualify yourself
- C. Accept only after award
- D. Tell the bidder to wait

### WHY

Unreported contacts are the most common violation and surface in protests years later.

**What is the 207 lifetime ban?**

A. Never working for a contractor

✓ **B. Never representing anyone to the government, with intent to influence, on a particular matter you participated in personally and substantially**

C. Never contacting your former agency

D. Never holding a clearance

**WHY**

Narrow: that matter, in a representational role. Working for the company is not barred.

**The 207 two-year ban covers:**

A. All matters in the industry

✓ **B. Matters under your official responsibility in your last year, even if you did not personally work them**

C. Only contracts you signed

D. Nothing for civilians

**WHY**

A division chief is covered for everything the division handled.

**Who is generally not covered by the 18 U.S.C. 207 bans?**

A. Officers

B. Civilian employees

✓ **C. Enlisted members**

D. SES

**WHY**

Enlisted members remain subject to the seeking-employment rules and the Procurement Integrity Act. Verify with ethics counsel.

**The Procurement Integrity Act one-year compensation ban applies to:**

A. Everyone who leaves government

✓ **B. Specified roles (CO, SSA, evaluation board members, PM, deputy PM, ACO) and specified decisions on contracts above the threshold, from that contractor**

C. Only generals

D. Only civilians

**WHY**

It runs from the last covered action, which may be well before separation.

**Which of these may you take to a new employer?**

A. Source selection information

✓ **B. Your skills, your understanding of how the organization works and decides, your relationships, and public information**

C. Contractor proposal information

D. Non-public budget plans

**WHY**

Help them understand the customer; never tell them what it plans to buy or what it thought of their last proposal.

**What is the DoD ethics opinion letter?**

A. A recommendation letter

✓ **B. A written ethics opinion, required for certain senior and acquisition officials before accepting defense contractor compensation within two years of leaving, and advisable for everyone**

C. A clearance document

D. A contract

**WHY**

Contractors are required to confirm it exists for covered hires. Free, fast, and the best protection.

**Match the rule to its duration:****CORRECT MATCHES**

|                                                  |                                  |
|--------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| 207 ban on matters you personally worked         | Lifetime                         |
| 207 ban on matters under official responsibility | Two years                        |
| Procurement Integrity Act compensation ban       | One year from the covered action |
| Senior official cooling-off                      | One year from leaving            |

**WHY**

Lifetime for matters you worked; two years for official responsibility; one year for the compensation ban and the senior cooling-off.

**Order the clean path through a transition to a contractor:****CORRECT ORDER**

1. Disqualify in writing when you first engage with a company whose matters you touch
2. Ask ethics counsel which bans apply to your rank and roles
3. Wait out any compensation ban from a specific contractor
4. Obtain an ethics opinion letter before accepting
5. Keep the memos and the letter for as long as the bans run

**WHY**

Disqualify at first contact, identify applicable bans, wait where required, get the letter, keep the file.

**Does a consulting arrangement with a contractor fall under these rules?**

A. No; only full-time employment counts

**✓ B. Yes; consulting, board seats, retainers, and speaking fees are compensation and representation for these purposes**

C. Only if over \$100,000

D. Only for civilians

**WHY**

Any arrangement where a defense contractor pays you within two years gets an ethics opinion first.

## VETERAN TRANSITION: FROM UNIFORM TO ACQUISITION · LESSON 6

# Starting a Veteran-Owned Business: SDVOSB, VOSB, and the First Contract

22 min

*What the veteran-owned business programs actually give you: SBA certification for SDVOSB and VOSB, the ownership and control tests that most disqualifications turn on, where the preferences apply (SDVOSB government-wide, VOSB mainly at VA), sole-source authority and its limits, how a first contract is realistically won, the fronting and control traps that produce enforcement cases, and what to decide before you file.*

## What the Programs Are, and What They Are Not

The veteran-owned programs give certified companies access to contracts set aside for them and, for SDVOSBs, to sole-source awards under a ceiling. They do not give you a contract. A certified SDVOSB with no capability, no past performance, and no customer relationships is a certified company with nothing to sell; a capable company with the certification has a door that its competitors do not. The small business module covers the set-aside programs together; this lesson is the veteran-specific view: what certification requires, where the preferences actually apply, how a first contract is realistically won, and the traps that turn a good company into an enforcement case.

### IN PLAIN TERMS

Picture a farmers market with a reserved section for certain vendors. The badge gets you a table in that section, away from most of the competition. It does not sell a single tomato: shoppers still buy from the stall with good produce and a vendor they know. And the badge only counts if the person named on it actually runs the stall. Service-disabled veteran-owned (SDVOSB) and veteran-owned (VOSB) small business certification works the same way: it opens set-aside doors, but capability, customers, and real veteran control win the work.

## Certification: Ownership and Control

Since 2023, SBA certifies both SDVOSBs and VOSBs through its Veteran Small Business Certification program (verify the current process and any changes). The tests are ownership and control. Ownership: at least 51 percent unconditionally and directly owned by one or more veterans (service-disabled veterans for SDVOSB), with the veteran's ownership not subject to agreements that could shift it. Control: the qualifying veteran holds the highest officer position, manages the company day to day, has the managerial and technical experience to do so, works for the company as their primary occupation during normal hours, and controls the board and all long-term decisions. Control is where most applications and most protests

fail. A veteran who owns 51 percent but whose non-veteran partner runs operations, signs the contracts, and holds the customer relationships does not control the company, whatever the paperwork says. Investor rights, supermajority provisions, and buy-sell agreements that could strip the veteran's control are examined closely.

#### EXAMPLE (ILLUSTRATIVE)

A service-disabled veteran and a non-veteran partner start a logistics services company. The veteran owns 60 percent and the partner owns 40 percent, so ownership passes the 51 percent test. The veteran is the top officer, works there full time, runs operations day to day, and signs the contracts, so control passes too. In year two, an investor offers money for a 15 percent stake. If those shares come out of the veteran's holding, the veteran drops to  $60 - 15 = 45$  percent, below 51, and the company no longer qualifies. Taking the stake from the partner instead ( $40 - 15 = 25$  percent) keeps the veteran at 60. Separately, if the partner starts signing the contracts and holding the customer relationships, the company fails the control test even at 60 percent ownership.

### Where the Preferences Apply

| PROGRAM              | SET-ASIDES                                                                     | SOLE SOURCE                                                                                       | WHERE                                                   |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| SDVOSB               | Government-wide, when the Rule of Two is met for SDVOSBs                       | Government-wide, under the ceiling, when the CO determines one SDVOSB can perform at a fair price | All agencies; DoD uses it regularly                     |
| VOSB                 | At VA under Vets First; elsewhere only as a plain small business               | At VA under Vets First                                                                            | Effectively a VA program outside of VA's own goals      |
| Vets First (VA)      | SDVOSB then VOSB priority ahead of other programs, when the Rule of Two is met | SDVOSB and VOSB sole source under VA's thresholds                                                 | VA only; the strongest veteran preference in government |
| Subcontracting goals | Large primes have SDVOSB subcontracting goals in their plans                   | Not applicable                                                                                    | Every large prime; a real source of first subcontracts  |

### How a First Contract Is Actually Won

A new SDVOSB has certification, an owner's record, and usually no company past performance. First contracts come from four places. Subcontracts from large primes that need SDVOSB participation to meet their subcontracting plan goals; the prime's small business liaison office is the door, and the owner's customer knowledge is the pitch. Small set-aside awards from contracting offices that know the owner, typically services the owner performed in uniform, under the simplified acquisition threshold where the process is fast. Sole-source awards, which require a CO willing to make the determination and a

requirement that fits under the ceiling; these happen when a program office wants a specific capability the owner has and the CO has an SDVOSB certification to justify it. And VA work under Vets First for companies with VA-relevant capabilities. What does not work: waiting for set-aside solicitations to appear on SAM.gov and bidding cold. The small business module's lesson on the machinery that produces awards applies in full.

## Before You File: The Decisions

- **What do you sell?** A capability a government office buys, that you have personally performed, at a price you can build from real costs. Not "consulting."
- **Who buys it?** Named offices that buy it now, from whom, under what vehicles. If you cannot name three, you are not ready.
- **Who else is on the cap table?** Any non-veteran partner or investor must fit under the 51 percent and the control tests, and the operating agreement must be written accordingly.
- **Who runs it?** The qualifying veteran, full time, as the top officer, with the competence to do so. If that is not the plan, the certification will not hold.
- **How will you survive the first year?** Contracts take months to win and months to pay. Savings, a billable job on the side (with the conflict rules observed), or a subcontract that pays early.
- **What is the compliance floor?** SAM, CAGE, an accounting method, insurance, and the on-ramp module's contract-ready checklist.

### WHEN SOMEONE OFFERS TO MAKE YOU THE OWNER

Every year, prosecutors announce cases where a non-veteran-owned company put a veteran's name on the paperwork, won set-aside contracts, and paid the veteran a salary while the real owners ran everything. The veterans in those cases often thought they were doing a friend a favor. They were committing fraud, and some went to prison. If someone offers to make you the owner of their company so it can win SDVOSB work, the answer is no. If you are building a company with a non-veteran partner who has the industry experience you lack, structure it honestly: you own and control it, you run it, and the partner is an employee or a minority owner without control, or it is not an SDVOSB.

One sentence to teach your team: **certification gives a capable, veteran-controlled company doors its competitors lack, sole source for SDVOSBs everywhere and first priority at VA, but the veteran must own 51 percent unconditionally and actually run the company, and the first contract still comes from a customer who knows you, not from a solicitation you found online.**

**INTERMEDIATE**

## **SDVOSB Sole Source: How It Works From the Government Side**

A contracting officer may award to a certified SDVOSB without competition when the CO does not expect two or more SDVOSBs to submit offers, the anticipated value is under the sole-source ceiling (different thresholds for manufacturing and for everything else; verify current), the award can be made at a fair and reasonable price, and the SDVOSB is responsible. The CO documents the determination. In practice, sole-source awards happen when a program office wants a specific small company for a specific reason, and the SDVOSB certification gives the CO a lawful way to award directly. This means the company's job is to create the reason: a capability the office needs, demonstrated through a subcontract, a small award, or the owner's record, so that the program office asks its CO for the sole source. Companies that ask COs for sole-source awards cold are rarely successful; companies whose program office customers ask usually are.

## **Teaming, Mentors, and Borrowing What You Lack**

A new veteran-owned company lacks past performance, infrastructure, and sometimes technical depth. The small business module's lesson on mentor-protégé and joint ventures covers the mechanics; here is the veteran application. SBA's mentor-protégé program lets a large company mentor your firm and form a joint venture that competes for set-asides using the mentor's past performance and resources, without affiliation. Large primes with SDVOSB subcontracting goals are motivated mentors. A joint venture with a more established SDVOSB is another route. Subcontracting to a prime on a contract in your capability area builds the company past performance that makes the next bid credible. Each of these carries the limitations on subcontracting and the control requirements: the SDVOSB must perform its required share and must control the joint venture. Borrow capability, not control.

## **The VA Opportunity and Its Limits**

Vets First makes VA the most veteran-friendly buyer in government: VA must set aside for SDVOSBs and VOSBs when the Rule of Two is met, before considering any other program, and it has its own sole-source thresholds. VA buys medical services, facilities, IT, logistics, construction, and much else. For a company with a relevant capability, VA is often the first customer. The limits: VA's preference does not extend to other agencies, VA's contracting is concentrated in specific product and service areas, and the VA set-aside market is competitive because every certified company knows about it. A DoD-focused company should not expect VA to be its market, and a VA-focused company should not expect DoD to treat VOSB status as a preference.

## **The Compliance Traps Specific to Veteran-Owned Firms**

Beyond fronting, the cases that reach enforcement involve a few recurring patterns. Control drift: the company starts veteran-controlled and, as a non-veteran partner takes over operations, stops being so,

without anyone updating the certification or the reps. Ownership dilution: a financing or a partner buyout takes the veteran below 51 percent or adds conditions to the ownership. Death or departure of the qualifying veteran: the company continues to claim status it no longer has (there are limited surviving-spouse provisions for SDVOSBs; verify). Pass-through: the SDVOSB wins a set-aside and subcontracts the work to a large company beyond the limitations on subcontracting. And misrepresentation in SAM: the reps and certs still say SDVOSB after the facts changed. Each of these is a False Claims Act exposure on every invoice submitted under the false status. Recertify honestly, update the reps when the facts change, and get out of the program the day you no longer qualify.

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**ADVANCED**

## Structuring the Company for Growth Without Losing Status

The tension in a growing veteran-owned company is that growth wants capital and experienced partners, and both threaten the ownership and control tests. Founders who manage it keep the veteran's ownership at or above 51 percent through every round, take investment as non-voting or minority equity without control rights that could override the veteran, write the operating agreement so the veteran controls the board and the long-term decisions unambiguously, hire the non-veteran operators as employees with authority delegated from the veteran rather than as partners with independent authority, and document the veteran's actual day-to-day management. They also plan the exit from the program: SDVOSB status ends when the company outgrows its size standards or the veteran sells, and the small business module's graduation lesson applies. A company that has built real capability and customer relationships survives graduation; one that only had the certification does not.

## Selling the Company: What the Status Is Worth to a Buyer

When a veteran-owned company is sold, the status does not transfer to a non-veteran buyer, and set-aside contracts may be affected: contracts won as an SDVOSB set-aside generally require the company to recertify status after a merger or acquisition, and an acquirer that is not an SDVOSB may lose the ability to receive future set-aside orders on those vehicles (verify the current recertification rules and the treatment of existing contracts). Buyers know this and discount accordingly. The value a buyer pays for is the customer relationships, the capability, the past performance, and the full-and-open or non-set-aside contracts. A founder building toward a sale should be building those from the start, using the set-aside advantage to get in and then competing on capability, so that the company is worth something to a buyer who cannot use the certification.

## The First Two Years, One Realistic Sequence

How a capable veteran-owned company typically reaches sustainable revenue.

**Months 0 to 3: Set up and certify** FOUNDATION

Entity, SAM, CAGE, accounting, insurance; SBA VetCert application; operating agreement written to the control test.

Certification takes time; apply early and keep working while it processes.

**Months 3 to 9: First subcontract** REVENUE

A prime with SDVOSB goals in your capability area; the owner's customer knowledge is the pitch; the subcontract builds past performance and cash.

Small business liaison offices exist to find you. Use them.

**Months 9 to 18: First prime award** PRIME

A small set-aside or sole-source award from a program office that knows the owner's work; simplified acquisition where possible.

The customer asks the CO. You do not ask cold.

**Months 18 to 24: Repeatable** SCALE

Two or three contracts across two customers; a mentor-protégé or teaming arrangement for larger set-asides; hiring beyond the founder.

Keep the veteran in control as the company grows; document it.

**WHAT SENIOR PMS DO DIFFERENTLY**

Contracting officers who use the SDVOSB programs well pair them with program offices that want a specific capable company and document the determination properly. Veteran founders who build durable companies certify honestly and keep control real as they grow, win the first contract through a customer who knows them, use primes' subcontracting goals and mentor-protégé to borrow capability without borrowing control, plan for graduation and for what a buyer will pay for, and walk away from any arrangement that would make them a front.

**BUILD ON THIS**

- **The Set-Aside Programs** SDVOSB among the other programs
- **Small Business Compliance Traps** How good companies end up in enforcement
- **Mentor-Protégé and Joint Ventures** Borrowing capability without affiliation

## Key Terms

### **SDVOSB**

Service-Disabled Veteran-Owned Small Business: at least 51 percent unconditionally owned and controlled by one or more service-disabled veterans, who manage day-to-day operations and make long-term decisions. Certified by SBA.

### **VOSB**

Veteran-Owned Small Business: the same ownership and control tests for veterans without a service-connected disability rating. Certified by SBA; preferences apply mainly at the Department of Veterans Affairs.

### **SBA VetCert**

The SBA certification program for SDVOSB and VOSB, which took over certification from VA in 2023. Certification is required to compete for set-asides and sole-source awards under the programs. Verify current process.

### **Unconditional Ownership**

Ownership not subject to conditions, agreements, or arrangements that could shift control or benefit to a non-veteran. Buy-sell agreements, options, and investor rights are scrutinized.

### **Control**

The service-disabled veteran holds the highest officer position, manages day-to-day operations, has the technical and managerial competence to do so, and controls the board and long-term decisions. The test most companies fail.

### **Sole Source**

An award without competition to a certified SDVOSB when the CO determines only one can perform, the price is fair, and the anticipated value is under the sole-source ceiling. Verify current thresholds.

### **Vets First**

The VA's program giving SDVOSBs and VOSBs first priority in VA contracting, with set-asides and sole-source authority ahead of other programs. The strongest veteran preference in government, and it applies only at VA.

### **Fronting**

A non-veteran-controlled company that uses a veteran as nominal owner to obtain set-aside contracts. A crime and the subject of regular prosecutions.

### **Rule of Two**

The set-aside requirement when the CO expects at least two capable small businesses (or SDVOSBs for an SDVOSB set-aside) to submit fair offers.

### **Past Performance**

Documented performance on prior contracts, which a new company does not have and must substitute with the owner's personal record, subcontracts, teaming, or a mentor.

## Knowledge Check

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What does SDVOSB certification give a company?

A. A contract

✓ **B. Access to SDVOSB set-asides and sole-source awards under a ceiling; it does not provide capability, past performance, or customers**

C. Exemption from SAM registration

D. Automatic VA contracts

### WHY

A door, not a sale.

Who certifies SDVOSBs and VOSBs now?

A. The Department of Veterans Affairs

✓ **B. SBA, through its Veteran Small Business Certification program, since 2023**

C. DoD

D. Each state

### WHY

Verify the current process; certification is required to compete under the programs.

Which test do most applications and protests fail?

A. Size

✓ **B. Control: the veteran must hold the top position, run day-to-day operations, have the competence to do so, and control the board and long-term decisions**

C. NAICS

D. Ownership percentage alone

### WHY

Fifty-one percent on paper while a partner runs the company is not control.

**Where does VOSB status carry a preference?**

A. Government-wide

✓ **B. Mainly at the Department of Veterans Affairs under Vets First**

C. DoD only

D. Nowhere

**WHY**

Outside VA, a VOSB competes as a plain small business.

**What is Vets First?**

A. A DoD hiring program

✓ **B. VA's program giving SDVOSBs and VOSBs first priority in VA contracting, with set-asides and sole source ahead of other programs**

C. An SBA loan

D. A mentor-protégé variant

**WHY**

The strongest veteran preference in government, and VA only.

**Where do first contracts for a new SDVOSB realistically come from?**

A. Cold bids on SAM.gov set-asides

✓ **B. Prime subcontracts to meet SDVOSB goals, small set-asides from offices that know the owner, sole source when a program office asks its CO, and VA under Vets First**

C. Grants

D. Unsolicited proposals

**WHY**

Waiting for solicitations and bidding cold does not work.

**What is fronting?**

A. Bidding first

✓ **B. A non-veteran-controlled company using a veteran as nominal owner to win set-asides; a crime regularly prosecuted**

C. Subcontracting

D. A teaming arrangement

**WHY**

If someone offers to make you the owner of their company for this purpose, the answer is no.

**For an SDVOSB sole-source award, the CO must determine:**

A. Only that the company is certified

✓ **B. That two or more SDVOSBs are not expected to offer, the value is under the ceiling, the price is fair and reasonable, and the company is responsible**

C. That the company is veteran-owned by 25 percent

D. Nothing; it is automatic

**WHY**

In practice, the program office wants the company and the CO uses the authority.

**What is control drift?**

A. Changing NAICS codes

✓ **B. A company that starts veteran-controlled and, as a non-veteran partner takes over operations, stops being so without updating certification or reps**

C. Losing a contract

D. A size protest

**WHY**

Every invoice under a false status is a False Claims Act exposure.

**Match the growth need to the status-preserving approach:****CORRECT MATCHES**

|                              |                                                                                        |
|------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Need capital                 | Minority or non-voting equity without control rights over the veteran                  |
| Need an experienced operator | Hire as an employee with delegated authority, not a partner with independent authority |
| Need past performance        | Prime subcontract or mentor-protégé joint venture                                      |
| Need larger set-asides       | Joint venture the SDVOSB controls, performing its required share                       |

**WHY**

Borrow capability, not control.

**Order the first two years of a veteran-owned company:****CORRECT ORDER**

1. Entity, registrations, accounting, and the VetCert application
2. First subcontract from a prime with SDVOSB goals
3. First prime award: small set-aside or sole source from a customer who knows the owner
4. Two or three contracts across two customers with a teaming or mentor arrangement

**WHY**

Set up and certify, first subcontract, first prime award, then repeatable revenue.

**Why does a buyer discount an SDVOSB's set-aside contracts?**

A. They are lower margin

**✓ B. The status does not transfer to a non-veteran buyer, and set-aside contracts may require recertification after acquisition, so the buyer pays for capability, customers, and non-set-aside work**

C. Set-aside contracts are short

D. The government cancels them

**WHY**

Use the set-aside advantage to get in, then compete on capability. Verify current recertification rules.

## VETERAN TRANSITION: FROM UNIFORM TO ACQUISITION · LESSON 7

# The First Ninety Days and the Five-Year Map: Culture, Credibility, and Building a Career Without Rank

22 min

*What the first three months in an acquisition job actually feel like for a veteran and how to use them: the culture differences that matter (consensus over command, years over days, writing over briefing, peers with vetoes), how credibility is built when no one can read your rank, the mistakes that mark a new arrival, a ninety-day plan, and then a five-year map through certifications, moves between government and industry, and the decision points that shape an acquisition career.*

## The Feeling of the First Month

Most veterans describe the first month in acquisition the same way: quiet, slow, and confusing. No one tells you what to do. Meetings end without decisions. Documents circulate for weeks. People who seem junior push back on people who seem senior, and nothing happens to them. Deadlines are discussed as aspirations. You may conclude that the organization is broken. It is not, or not in the way it looks. It is an organization where authority is distributed by statute and regulation among people who do not report to each other, where the money moves on an annual cycle set by Congress, and where every significant decision is written down, reviewed, and defensible. The pace and the ambiguity are features of that structure. The first ninety days are for learning how it actually works, before trying to change any of it.

### IN PLAIN TERMS

Think of renovating a condo. The building manager, the city inspector, the condo board, and your lender each hold a piece of the yes, and none of them works for you. Telling them what to do gets you nowhere. Asking each one what they need before the board meeting gets the work approved. A program office runs the same way: the program manager, contracting officer, legal, test, and finance each hold a piece of the decision, and agreement is built before the meeting, not in it.

## The Culture Differences That Matter

| IN UNIFORM                                 | IN ACQUISITION                                                                               | WHAT TO DO                                                                            |
|--------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| The commander decides; the staff executes  | The decision is assembled from the PM, CO, legal, test, finance, and user, each with a piece | Learn who holds which piece; build agreement before the meeting, not in it            |
| Timelines in days and weeks                | Timelines in months and years, tied to the budget cycle                                      | Plan against the calendar that exists; do not promise speed the system cannot deliver |
| Brief it                                   | Write it: the memo, the decision paper, the email with options and a recommendation          | Learn the formats the organization uses; write more than you talk                     |
| Rank tells people how to read you          | Nothing does; credibility is built from work product                                         | Deliver something sound and on time in the first month; repeat                        |
| Regulations are constraints to work around | Regulations are the authority that lets anything happen at all                               | Ask why the rule exists before asking how to get around it                            |
| Informality signals a lack of seriousness  | Informality is normal; seriousness shows in the document                                     | Do not mistake first names and open doors for a lack of standards                     |
| Push through obstacles                     | Obstacles are often other people's lawful authority                                          | Find out whose authority it is and what they need to say yes                          |

## How Credibility Is Built

In acquisition, credibility comes from three things, and all of them are slow. Your written work is sound: the numbers add up, the regulation is cited correctly, the options are real, the recommendation is defensible. Your commitments hold: when you say the input will be ready Thursday, it is. And you understand the constraints: you know why the CO cannot do what you asked, why the budget analyst needs the appropriation named, why the tester will not sign until the criteria are met. A veteran who arrives with operational knowledge has a head start on understanding the mission; the credibility that matters in the office is built on the other three, one document and one kept commitment at a time. Six months is a normal horizon for it. Expect that.

## Mistakes That Mark a New Arrival

- **Giving orders to peers** Especially the contracting officer. It generates resistance you will not see and cannot fix.
- **Announcing how it was done in the unit** Everyone has heard it. Ask how it is done here, and why.
- **Promising speed** A commitment the system cannot keep makes you the one who did not understand.
- **Briefing instead of writing** The slide deck that would have worked at the command is not the format. Write the memo.

- **Treating civilians as support staff** The GS-13 who has run this program for eight years knows more than you will for two years. Learn from them.
- **Skipping the ethics counselor** Especially if you are talking to contractors or came from one. Ask early.
- **Using military vocabulary** It marks you as untranslated and it confuses people. Use the organization's words.

#### THE QUESTION TO ASK IN YOUR FIRST MONTH

The single most useful thing you can do in the first month is find the person who has been in the office the longest and ask them to explain how a decision actually gets made here: who has to agree, in what order, and what each of them needs. Then ask what the last new arrival got wrong. That conversation, repeated with two or three people, is worth more than any orientation, and the people you ask will remember that you asked.

## A Ninety-Day Plan

Days one to thirty: learn. Read the program's core documents (the acquisition strategy, the contract, the budget, the schedule), meet everyone who touches the program and ask what they do and what they need from your role, find a mentor, and deliver one small thing well. Days thirty-one to sixty: contribute. Take ownership of a piece of the work (a report, a review, a coordination), produce it in the organization's format and on its timeline, and begin building agreement with the peers whose sign-off you will need on larger things. Days sixty-one to ninety: assess. You now know enough to see what could be better. Write it down, with the constraints you have learned, and discuss it with the mentor before proposing anything. Most of what looked broken in month one will look different in month three; what still looks broken is where you can add value, carefully.

One sentence to teach your team: **acquisition distributes authority among peers who do not report to each other and moves on a yearly budget calendar, so the first ninety days are for learning who holds which piece of a decision and building credibility through sound written work and kept commitments, not for fixing anything.**

#### INTERMEDIATE

## The Five-Year Map: Government Side

For a veteran entering as a government civilian, the first five years usually look like this. Year one: enter at GS-11 or GS-12 (or in a developmental program), start DAWIA training, learn the program. Year two: reach the first certification tier in your functional area, take ownership of a significant piece of a program, build the relationships across the office. Year three: GS-12 or GS-13, practitioner-level certification where

it exists, consider a rotation (a different program, a different functional area, a tour in a headquarters or a contracting office) to broaden. Years four and five: GS-13, deputy program manager or a team lead or a contracting officer with a warrant, and the decision point: stay on the technical or contracting track, move into program management leadership, take a headquarters or joint assignment, or cross over to industry with a certification, a clearance, and a customer network in hand. The government path rewards patience and breadth; the people who reach GS-14 and GS-15 have usually done two or three different things.

## The Five-Year Map: Contractor Side

For a veteran entering with a contractor, the arc from the contractor lesson applies: a billable role supporting a familiar customer, then a second contract or a larger role, then capture involvement, then a choice. Add the credentials: a PMP in the first two years is worth having on the contractor side, and DAWIA-equivalent training through DAU is open to contractors for many courses. Add the moves: contractors reward people who can be placed on new work, so breadth across two or three customers and two or three kinds of contracts is as valuable as depth. And add the crossing: many contractor employees move into government at GS-13 or GS-14 after five to seven years, bringing industry experience that program offices value, or start companies. The contractor path rewards visibility and revenue contribution; the people who reach director level have usually helped win something.

## Credentials and What They Are Worth Where

| CREDENTIAL                                                          | GOVERNMENT VALUE                          | CONTRACTOR VALUE                            | HOW OBTAINED                                                                           |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| DAWIA certification (by functional area and tier)                   | Required for the position; the ladder     | Recognized; signals government fluency      | DAU training plus experience, on government time; some DAU courses open to contractors |
| PMP                                                                 | Helpful, not required                     | Widely expected for PM roles                | PMI exam after documented experience and training                                      |
| Contracting officer warrant                                         | The credential in the 1102 field          | Highly valued in contracts management roles | Certification plus experience plus appointment by the agency                           |
| Security clearance                                                  | Required for many positions               | A salary premium and placement flexibility  | Sponsored investigation; maintained through sponsorship                                |
| Degree (bachelor's, master's)                                       | Required for some series; helps for grade | Required by many labor categories           | GI Bill; many programs are online and employer-supported                               |
| Specialized certifications (cost estimating, logistics, EVM, cyber) | Valued in the functional area             | Valued in the matching labor categories     | Professional bodies; often employer-paid                                               |

## Using the GI Bill and Employer Education Benefits

The education benefits earned in service are a career tool, not just a personal one. A bachelor's degree is required for the 1102 series and for many labor categories; a master's in acquisition, systems engineering, business, or public administration is common at the GS-14 and director levels and is often completed part time in the first five years. Many programs are online and designed for working professionals. Government employers have tuition assistance and academic degree training programs in some cases; contractors often have tuition reimbursement. Plan the degree against the career map: the credential that unlocks the next grade or the next labor category is the one to pursue first.

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### ADVANCED

## Crossing Over, and When It Works

The move between government and industry works best at specific points. From government to industry: after a certification and a warrant or a deputy PM role, with a clearance current and a customer network that a contractor can use, and with the ethics rules handled in writing. From industry to government: after several years on programs with a record of delivery, a clearance, and the translated resume that shows scope and outcomes in government terms; the special authorities for veterans still apply, and industry experience is valued in program offices that struggle to understand contractors. Each crossing resets some things (seniority, benefits, the network on the other side) and carries some things (the clearance, the credentials, the reputation). People who cross more than twice in a career are common in acquisition and are often the most effective, because they understand both sides.

## Leadership in Acquisition: What Senior Veterans Eventually Bring

After the first years, the things that made the transition hard become advantages. A veteran who has learned to build consensus can lead a program office through a milestone review with every stakeholder aligned, which is the hardest thing a government PM does. A veteran who has learned the budget calendar can plan a program across the POM years, which most people cannot. A veteran who has learned to write can produce the decision paper that moves a senior leader. And the operational judgment that came from service, applied to the question of what actually matters to the user, is what separates a program that fields something useful from one that meets its specification. The path from a confused first month to a senior role is the same path everyone in acquisition walks; veterans who make the cultural shift early tend to walk it faster.

## Decision Points on the Map

The forks that shape an acquisition career, and how to think about each.

**Year 1: Government or contractor** ENTRY

Stability and the defined ladder, or pay and speed. Both lead to the same senior roles by different routes.

Choose by what you want the next five years to feel like.

**Year 3: Depth or breadth** SHAPE

Become the expert in one functional area, or rotate to understand several. Senior roles usually require both, in sequence.

Depth first if you entered without a specialty; breadth first if you brought one.

**Year 5: Technical track, leadership, or crossing** FORK

Senior specialist or CO, program leadership, or the move to the other side.

The credentials, clearance, and network you have built decide which doors are open.

**Year 7 to 10: Ownership or seniority** COMMIT

Start or join a small company, or pursue GS-14/15, SES, or director roles.

The veteran business lesson covers the first; the same consensus and writing skills serve the second.

**WHAT SENIOR PMS DO DIFFERENTLY**

Leaders who develop veterans in acquisition assign a mentor in the first week, explain how decisions actually get made, give the new arrival one thing to deliver well in the first month, and treat the cultural adjustment as normal rather than as a deficiency. Veterans who thrive learn before they change anything, build credibility in writing and by keeping commitments, ask the longest-tenured colleague how the office works, plan credentials against the career map, and use the consensus skills they had to learn as the thing that later makes them effective leaders.

**BUILD ON THIS**

- **Stakeholder Management & Communication** The consensus skills in practice
- **Common Mistakes New PMs Make** The general version of the new-arrival list
- **The PM and CO Partnership** Working with the peer who has the warrant

## Key Terms

### Consensus Culture

Decision-making by agreement among people who do not report to each other. The default in acquisition, where the PM, CO, tester, budget analyst, and user each hold a piece of the decision.

### Peer With a Veto

A colleague who cannot be ordered but whose agreement is required: the contracting officer, the legal reviewer, the test authority, the comptroller. Most of the people you will work with.

### Credibility

In acquisition, the accumulated evidence that your analysis is sound, your commitments hold, and you understand the constraints. Built in writing, over months, and not transferable from rank.

### The Memo

The written product that moves decisions in acquisition: a decision paper, an information paper, a justification, an email that states the problem, the options, and the recommendation. The acquisition equivalent of the briefing.

### DAWIA Certification

The tiered credential for the DoD acquisition workforce by functional area. The defined ladder for government acquisition careers and a recognized credential in industry.

### PMP

The Project Management Professional certification from the Project Management Institute. Widely recognized on the contractor side, less so in government, and complementary to DAWIA.

### Continuous Learning

The requirement to accrue learning points over a period to maintain acquisition certification, and the habit that keeps a career current.

### Crossing Over

Moving between government and industry roles, in either direction, usually at a point where a clearance, a certification, and a customer relationship are in hand.

### Rotation

A deliberate move between functional areas or organizations to broaden experience; common in the developmental programs and valuable at any stage.

### Mentor

An experienced person in the new organization who explains what is not written down. The single most useful thing to find in the first month.

## Knowledge Check

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Why does an acquisition office look broken to a new veteran?

A. Because it is

✓ **B. Because authority is distributed by statute among peers who do not report to each other, money moves on an annual cycle, and decisions are written and reviewed; the pace and ambiguity are features of that structure**

C. Because civilians are unmotivated

D. Because there is no leadership

### WHY

The first ninety days are for learning how it actually works.

What replaces the briefing as the product that moves decisions?

A. The phone call

✓ **B. The memo: a written decision paper, information paper, or email with the problem, options, and recommendation**

C. The meeting

D. The order

### WHY

Write more than you talk; learn the organization's formats.

How is credibility built in acquisition?

A. By rank and awards

✓ **B. Through sound written work, commitments that hold, and understanding the constraints, over about six months**

C. By speaking up in meetings

D. By working long hours

### WHY

One document and one kept commitment at a time.

**Which mistake most marks a new arrival?**

A. Asking questions

✓ B. Giving orders to peers, especially the contracting officer

C. Reading the contract

D. Finding a mentor

**WHY**

It generates resistance you will not see and cannot fix.

**What should the first thirty days be spent on?**

A. Proposing changes

✓ B. Reading the core program documents, meeting everyone who touches the program, finding a mentor, and delivering one small thing well

C. Reorganizing the office

D. Negotiating a promotion

**WHY**

Learn, then contribute, then assess.

**What is the most useful first-month conversation?**

A. With the commander

✓ B. With the longest-tenured colleague: how a decision actually gets made here, who must agree, in what order, and what the last new arrival got wrong

C. With HR

D. With a recruiter

**WHY**

Worth more than any orientation, and remembered.

On the government five-year map, what typically happens at year five?

A. Retirement

✓ B. GS-13, a deputy PM, team lead, or warranted CO role, and the decision point among technical track, leadership, headquarters, or crossing to industry

C. GS-15

D. A mandatory rotation

**WHY**

The government path rewards patience and breadth.

Where is the PMP most valued?

A. Government, where it is required

✓ B. The contractor side, where it is widely expected for PM roles; helpful but not required in government

C. Nowhere

D. Only in construction

**WHY**

DAWIA is the government ladder; PMP complements it.

When does crossing from government to industry work best?

A. Immediately after entry

✓ B. After a certification and a warrant or deputy PM role, with a current clearance, a customer network, and the ethics rules handled in writing

C. Never

D. Only at GS-15

**WHY**

Each crossing resets some things and carries the clearance, credentials, and reputation.

**Match the uniform habit to the acquisition adjustment:****CORRECT MATCHES**

|                        |                                                                 |
|------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| The commander decides  | Build agreement among the peers who each hold a piece           |
| Timelines in days      | Plan against the annual budget calendar                         |
| Brief it               | Write the memo with options and a recommendation                |
| Push through obstacles | Find whose lawful authority it is and what they need to say yes |

**WHY**

Consensus, calendar, writing, and understanding authority replace command, speed, briefing, and pushing through.

**Order the ninety-day plan:****CORRECT ORDER**

1. Read the core documents, meet everyone, find a mentor, deliver one small thing well
2. Take ownership of a piece of the work and produce it in the organization's format and timeline
3. Begin building agreement with the peers whose sign-off larger work will need
4. Write down what could be better, with the constraints you have learned, and discuss it with the mentor

**WHY**

Learn, contribute, assess.

**Which service-derived strength becomes an advantage later in an acquisition career?**

A. Giving orders

✓ **B. Operational judgment about what actually matters to the user, combined with learned consensus, budget, and writing skills**

C. Military vocabulary

D. Speed at all costs

**WHY**

Veterans who make the cultural shift early tend to walk the path to senior roles faster.

VETERAN TRANSITION: FROM UNIFORM TO ACQUISITION · MODULE ASSESSMENT

# Module Assessment

Pass this to unlock the next skill level in the app.

## Knowledge Check

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The main difficulty in a veteran's transition into acquisition is:

- A. Learning new work from scratch
- ✓ B. Translating work already done into a vocabulary civilian readers understand
- C. Passing a certification exam
- D. Obtaining a clearance

### WHY

Planning, resourcing, leading, and delivering under regulation are the same work with different words.

The acquisition equivalent of an operations order is:

- A. The invoice
- ✓ B. The acquisition strategy and program plan
- C. The CPARS
- D. The requirement

### WHY

A written plan with phases, tasks, responsibilities, and decision points.

A Veterans Recruitment Appointment allows:

- A. Ten preference points
- ✓ B. Non-competitive appointment of an eligible veteran to positions up to GS-11
- C. Direct appointment to GS-14
- D. Waiver of the education requirement

### WHY

One of several special authorities that let a hiring manager bring a veteran in without full competition.

**HR reads a USAJOBS application as:**

A. A narrative

✓ **B. A screening instrument checked against the qualification standard and the specialized experience statement, in the announcement's words**

C. A cover letter

D. A rank record

**WHY**

A resume that does not use the announcement's language is rated ineligible.

**A contractor hires a veteran for a billable role because:**

A. Of rank

✓ **B. The person meets a labor category, holds the clearance, and brings customer credibility, and the salary is recovered from contract revenue**

C. It is required by law

D. Veterans work for less

**WHY**

This explains fast hiring, contingent offers, and contract-tied jobs.

**The recompute date matters to a contractor employee because:**

A. It sets the bonus

✓ **B. It is the position's horizon; the job continues or transfers depending on who wins**

C. It ends the clearance

D. It is when raises occur

**WHY**

Know the date, the competitors, and keep the customer relationship strong.

**After separation, clearance eligibility:**

A. Ends immediately

✓ **B. Remains for a window during which a new sponsor can reinstate it without a new investigation**

C. Becomes permanent

D. Transfers to any employer automatically

**WHY**

Commonly cited as two years from last access; verify current policy.

**The most common clearance flag in transition is:**

A. Foreign travel

✓ **B. Financial trouble from a job gap**

C. A new address

D. Starting school

**WHY**

Budget the gap and self-report with a plan.

**Under the ethics rules, seeking employment begins when:**

A. An offer is accepted

✓ **B. A resume is sent, a recruiter is answered with anything other than rejection, or terms are discussed**

C. Separation occurs

D. A contract is signed

**WHY**

The written disqualification duty starts at the first step.

**The 18 U.S.C. 207 lifetime ban prohibits:**

A. Working for any contractor

✓ **B. Representing anyone to the government, with intent to influence, on a particular matter you participated in personally and substantially**

C. Contacting a former agency for a year

D. Holding a clearance

**WHY**

Narrow and representational; enlisted members are generally not covered by 207.

**SDVOSB certification most often fails on:**

A. Size

✓ **B. Control: the veteran must hold the top position, run day-to-day operations, and control the board and long-term decisions**

C. NAICS

D. Revenue

**WHY**

Fifty-one percent on paper while a partner runs the company is not control.

**In the first ninety days, a veteran should:**

A. Reorganize the office

✓ **B. Learn who holds each piece of a decision and build credibility through sound written work and kept commitments**

C. Give orders to the contracting officer

D. Promise faster timelines

**WHY**

Learn, contribute, assess; do not fix anything in month one.